The Allotment Bible 2026–27

Your 125 m² plan: wedding flowers cut on Sunday 30 May 2027, plus a full year of veg, herbs and fruit.

Written 27 October 2026, revised 29 October 2026. Read Parts 1 to 6 once, then live in Part 7 (plant cards) and Part 8 (month-by-month checklist) all year.

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Part 1. Read this first

The eight findings that shape everything

Tulips will be over by 30 May if left in the ground. In southern England, even late tulips peak from mid-April to mid-May. Your handwritten plan (pull early, no water, wrap in newspaper, fridge, rehydrate) is exactly right and is not optional. Plan to pull the wedding tulips around 9–16 May at "colour showing" bud stage.

Five plants on your wedding list cannot realistically flower by 30 May from seed sown now (scabiosa, Didiscus, Achillea, clary sage, Lunaria). They are marked ❌ in Part 2, each with a fix (buy plants, use foliage, or save for a later event). **Two more, the Iceland poppies, are gambles (🎲):** sow them now anyway, but expect 0 to 1 stem per plant on the day. 'Bridal Silk' poppy is borderline (⚠).

Several crops need warmth your unheated cold frame cannot give, however many trays it holds. Tomatoes, peppers, onions, basil, Didiscus, eucalyptus, scabiosa (main sowing), rudbeckia, statice, lemon bergamot, lavender and helichrysum need a heated propagator or warm windowsill at home for germination.

Rodents are the number-one threat to your wedding. Bulbs, corms and sweet pea seed are what mice, voles and squirrels dig up first. Part 5 is a full defence plan, built into the layout.

Your list contains a whole family of brassicas in disguise. Stocks, Thlaspi, Lunaria and candytuft are cabbage relatives. They share clubroot and flea beetle with your two cabbages, so they are rotated together in Part 4.

Autumn sowing is the single biggest lever for May flowers. Hardy annuals sown in October and November flower 4–6 weeks earlier than spring sowings. You are at the late end of the window, so sow this week.

Your cold frame holds about 18 trays, and it is nearly full by 10 March (17.5 of 18). It runs on a schedule: the tray ledger in Part 3 shows what occupies it and when, and what to drop first if it overflows.

Back-up plans are built in. Every wedding flower has a second batch, a later sowing, or a cold-store trick so that no single failure empties the buckets.

Assumptions I have made (tell me if any are wrong)

Climate: mild coastal southern England. Average last frost around mid-April (frost still possible to early May). First frosts around late November. Dates shift by 1–2 weeks either way.

Bulbs, corms, tubers: anything with a count (tulips, ranunculus, dahlias) and the daffodils and alliums are bulbs, corms or tubers, not seed. Allium is assumed to be bulbs (variety not stated). Choose a late-flowering type for 30 May.

Ticks (✓) on your list are read as "already bought or sown". Everything is still included.

Cold frame: wooden, unheated. You estimate it holds about 18 standard seed trays (38 × 24 cm), and the plan uses that. Tray-equivalents for modules, plugs and root trainers are my estimates (24 modules, 40 plugs or about 32 root-trainer cells per tray).

Indoor warmth: you have a warm windowsill or can borrow one. Without it, buy tomato, pepper, onion and basil plants instead.

Plot history: unknown. If any part grew brassicas or onions in 2026, tell me and I will adjust the rotation.

Sweet peas: 74 sown in total: the 40 you listed plus 34 'Spring Sunshine' (seed). Only 48 go on the plot, 24 per planter, so they are not crowded: 24 Spring Sunshine in planter S1 and 24 of the others in S2. The other 26 go in your home garden.

Raised planters: 180 × 90 cm, 25 cm deep, no base. The plan buys 4 (2 at minimum), 1 of them now, and no extenders (Part 4).

Entrance: the plot has no gate or physical boundary. The layout treats the south end, where the main path starts, as where you arrive and work (confirmed by owner that there is no gate).

Quantities: you gave counts for bulbs and a few flowers. For everything else, each card suggests a target plant number.

Things I could not read or identify (please confirm)

Tulip "Beachberry" (handwriting): I have read it as the late double dusky-pink tulip 'Beachberry'.

"Shells on the Beach" ×20: this matches Sarah Raven's collection of five coral, mauve, apricot and coffee tulips. Is ×20 the total, or 20 of each?

"Light up the Shade" ×40: treated as a pale/white shade-tolerant tulip mix. Which varieties are in it?

"Phenomena … the brick" at the bottom of the left page (with "Papaver" crossed out): I could not identify this. Please tell me what it is.

"Lavender" (very faint, bottom right): included as a herb.

Dahlias ×7, Allium, Rudbeckia, Carrots, Daffodils: variety and colour not stated.

Key dates at a glance

Date	What happens
29 Oct 2026	Revised plan. Sow all 74 sweet peas (48 for the plot, 26 for your garden) and the hardy annuals this week. Plant tulips (first half, in planter T), daffodils and alliums
Early Nov	Pot up first half of ranunculus corms (1-8 Nov). Finish autumn sowing by 15 Nov
Late Nov (approx.)	First frosts. Cold frame lid and fleece go on
Early Jan 2027	Plant second half of tulips (3-10 Jan). Sow Didiscus late Jan
Late Feb 2027	Pot up second half of ranunculus. Main spring sowing begins
March 2027	Strawberry Fenella arrives. Plant out autumn-sown seedlings (15-25 Mar) and sweet peas (25 Mar-5 Apr, 48 on the plot)
Mid-April	Average last frost. Harden off, plant out
9–16 May	Pull early tulips for cold storage
Sun 30 May	Harvest day
Mon 31 May (bank holiday)	Condition, sort and arrange
Tue 1 June	The wedding

Part 2. Master plant list with wedding verdicts

Key: ✅ on track. ⚠ borderline, back-up plan needed. 🎲 gamble: sow anyway, expect 0 to 1 stem per plant on the day. ❌ will not flower in time (see fix). ❓ unknown. "Perennial?" says whether the plant comes back year after year. Asterisk = perennial in theory but treated as a one-year crop here.

Wedding flowers

Plant	Form	Life cycle	Perennial?	30 May verdict
Tulip 'Light up the Shade' ×40	Bulb	Perennial, grown as annual	Yes*	✅ with early-pull + cold store
Tulip 'Shells on the Beach' ×20	Bulb	Perennial, grown as annual	Yes*	✅ with early-pull + cold store
Tulip 'Mount Tacoma' ×25	Bulb	Perennial, grown as annual	Yes*	✅ late double, best natural fit
Tulip 'Beachberry' ×10	Bulb	Perennial, grown as annual	Yes*	✅ late double
Ranunculus 'Butterfly' ×3	Corm	Tender perennial	Yes*	✅ second batch
Ranunculus 'Amandine Pastel Pink' ×25	Corm	Tender perennial	Yes*	✅ both batches
Ranunculus pink ×50	Corm	Tender perennial	Yes*	✅ both batches
Ranunculus asiaticus ×1	Corm	Tender perennial	Yes*	✅
Allium (variety?)	Bulb	Perennial	Yes	✅ if a late variety
Stock 'Antique Rose' ✓	Seed	Half-hardy annual	No	✅ sow now + Feb backup
Stock 'Champagne' ✓	Seed	Half-hardy annual	No	✅ sow now + Feb backup
Stock 'White' ✓	Seed	Half-hardy annual	No	✅ sow now + Feb backup
Sweet peas ×40: 'Muse', 'Fire & Ice', 'High Scent' ✓	Seed	Hardy annual	No	✅
Sweet peas ×34: 'Spring Sunshine' ✓	Seed (assumed)	Hardy annual	No	✅ may start slightly earlier
Larkspur 'Pretty Pink'	Seed	Hardy annual	No	⚠ starts late May
Clarkia 'May Blossom'	Seed	Hardy annual	No	⚠ starts late May
Orlaya grandiflora	Seed	Hardy annual	No	✅
Nigella 'Persian Jewels'	Seed	Hardy annual	No	✅
Cornflower (maybe)	Seed	Hardy annual	No	✅
Poppy 'Bridal Silk'	Seed	Hardy annual	No	⚠ late May to June
Poppy 'Iceland Giant'	Seed	Short-lived perennial/biennial	Yes (short)	🎲 gamble, mainly June on
Poppy Colibri 'Dolce Vita'	Seed	Short-lived perennial/biennial	Yes (short)	🎲 gamble, mainly June on
Scabiosa 'Salmon Queen'	Seed	Half-hardy annual	No	❌ flowers from June
Thlaspi arvensis	Seed	Hardy annual	No	✅

Plant	Form	Life cycle	Perennial?	30 May verdict
Didiscus caerulea 'Lacy Pink'	Seed	Half-hardy annual	No	❌ flowers from June–July
Eucalyptus pulverulenta	Seed	Tender evergreen, grown as annual	Yes*	⚠ foliage only
Achillea 'The Pearl'	Seed	Perennial	Yes	❌ first-year flowers from July
Clary sage	Seed	Biennial (or annual, depending on species)	Yes/No	❌ see card
Lemon bergamot	Seed	Annual/short-lived perennial	No	⚠ foliage only
Lunaria 'Fine Mixed'	Seed	Biennial	No	❌ flowers spring 2028
Geum 'Cosmopolitan' ×5 (1 L pots)	Plant	Perennial	Yes	✅
"Phenomena … the brick"	?	?	?	❓

Other flowers (not for the wedding)

Plant	Form	Life cycle		Perennial?		Purpose
Daffodils	Bulb	Perennial		Yes		Spring colour, rodent barrier
Dahlias ×7	Tuber	Tender perennial		Yes (needs mulch or lifting)		Summer–autumn cutting
Candytuft 'Spangles'	Seed	Hardy annual		No		Summer filler
Marigold 'Fireball'	Seed	Annual		No		Pest-deterring companion
Rudbeckia	Seed	Annual or short-lived perennial		Depends		Summer–autumn cutting
Statice 'Pink Pokers'	Seed	Half-hardy annual		No		Drying
Helichrysum 'Kingsize Mixed'	Seed	Half-hardy annual		No		Drying
Helichrysum 'Silvery Rose'	Seed	Half-hardy annual		No		Drying
Vegetables and fruit						
Plant	Form		Life cycle		Perennial?	Harvest window
Beetroot 'Detroit 2'	Seed		Biennial, grown as annual		No	Jun–Oct
Onion 'Red Herald' F1	Seed		Biennial, grown as annual		No	Aug–Sep
Cabbage 'Primo II'	Seed		Biennial, grown as annual		No	Jul–Oct
Cabbage 'Red Kalibo'	Seed		Biennial, grown as annual		No	Aug–Nov
Carrot 'Harlequin' F1	Seed		Biennial, grown as annual		No	Jul–Nov

Plant		Form	Life cycle		Perennial?	Harvest window
Carrots (variety?)		Seed	Biennial, grown as annual		No	Jul–Nov
Tomato 'Buffalosteak'		Seed	Tender perennial, grown as annual		No	Aug–Oct
Tomato 'Toddler'		Seed	Tender perennial, grown as annual		No	Jul–Oct
Pepper, sweet hybrid		Seed	Tender perennial, grown as annual		No	Aug–Oct
Pepper 'Snackbite' mixed		Seed	Tender perennial, grown as annual		No	Aug–Oct
Strawberry 'Fenella'		Plant (March)	Perennial		Yes	Jun–Jul (full crop from 2028)
Herbs Plant Form Life cycle Perennial? Basil Seed Tender annual No Chives Seed Hardy perennial Yes Thyme Seed Evergreen perennial Yes Mint Seed/plant Hardy perennial (invasive) Yes Applemint Seed/plant Hardy perennial (invasive) Yes Rosemary Seed/plant Evergreen perennial shrub Yes Lavender Seed Evergreen perennial shrub Yes ❌ The fixes in one place						
Plant	Why not in time			Fix		
Achillea 'The Pearl'	Seed-raised plants flower from July in year one			Buy a 1 L plant in spring, or substitute extra Orlaya/Nigella as the white filler		

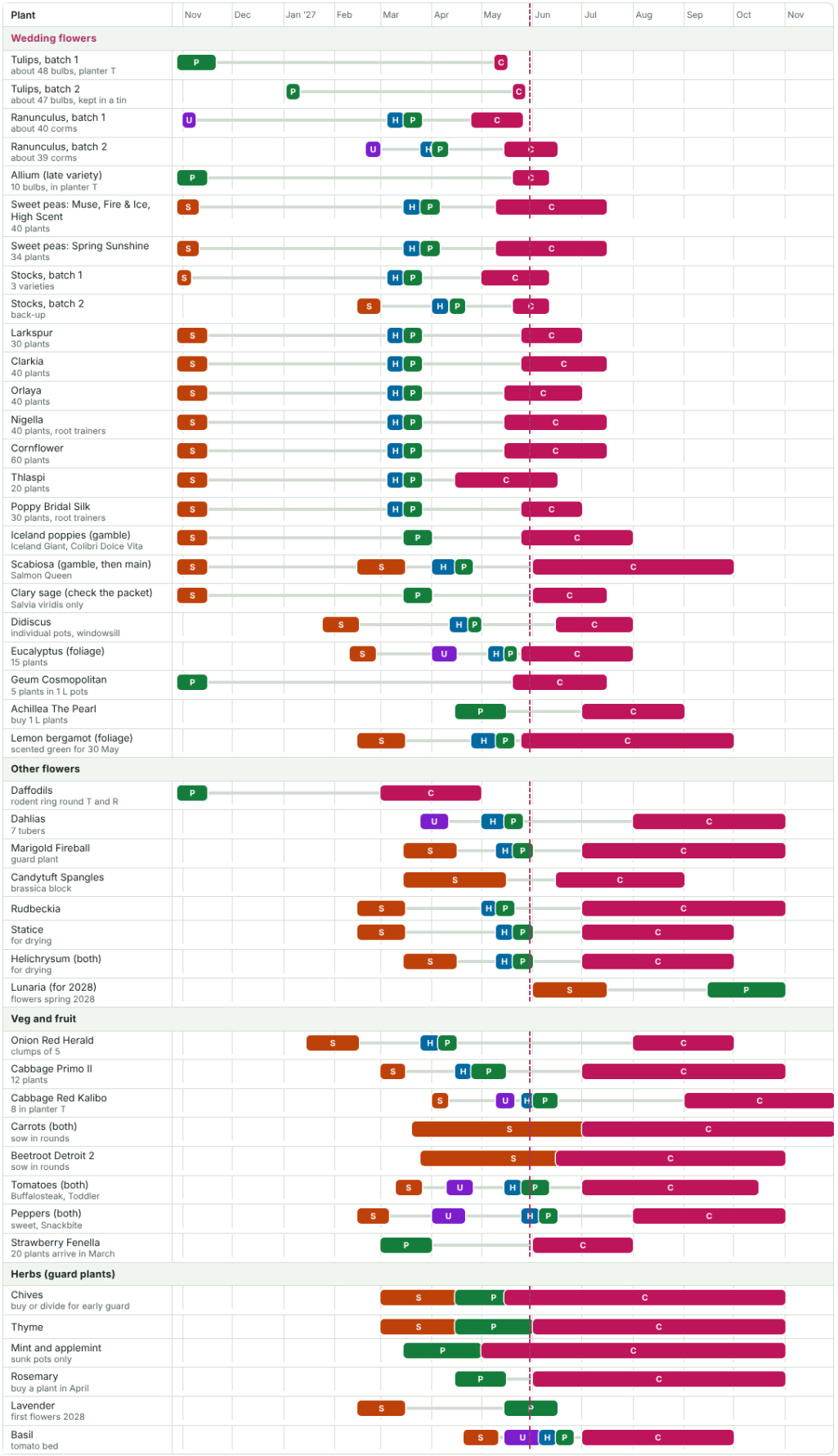
Plant	Form	Life cycle	Perennial?
Basil	Seed	Tender annual	No
Chives	Seed	Hardy perennial	Yes
Thyme	Seed	Evergreen perennial	Yes
Mint	Seed/plant	Hardy perennial (invasive)	Yes
Applemint	Seed/plant	Hardy perennial (invasive)	Yes
Rosemary	Seed/plant	Evergreen perennial shrub	Yes
Lavender	Seed	Evergreen perennial shrub	Yes

Plant	Why not in time	Fix
Clary sage	Biennial (Salvia sclarea): flowers in its second year, 2028. If your packet is the annual Salvia viridis, autumn sowing may flower in June	Check the packet. Use foliage if neither flowers
Lunaria	Biennial: sown now, flowers spring 2028	Sow in June 2027 for the following year
Didiscus	Half-hardy annual, no heated bench	Sow Jan–Feb on a warm windowsill. Treat any May flowers as a bonus
Scabiosa	Flowers from June. Autumn sowing may bring early flowers	Sow some now in the frost-free end of the frame as a gamble, plus Feb on a windowsill
Iceland poppies (both)	Packet windows (Apr-Jun, May-Jul) assume the packet's own sowing time. Ideal sowing is June–September for flowers the following spring; an end-October sowing gives small plants into winter	Now a gamble, not a red cross: sow now, plant out 15-31 Mar, expect 0 to 1 stem a plant by 30 May and flowers mainly June onward
Lemon bergamot	Flowers July–September	Use the lemon-scented foliage on 30 May

Part 3. Visual dashboards and calendar

This section holds your calendar, cold-frame ledger and stem forecast. Read them in this order: (1) the by-job calendar chart, (2) the cold-frame tray ledger, (3) the stem forecast for 30 May, (4) the countdown, (5) the by-job calendar tables. The plot layout is in Part 4.

Calendar by job: sow, pot up, harden off, plant out, harvest



Each row shows the five jobs separately, so you can see which operation is due when. The red dashed line is harvest day, 30 May. The exact dates are in the tables below. Carrot and beetroot bars show the

main windows: in practice you sow them in rounds.

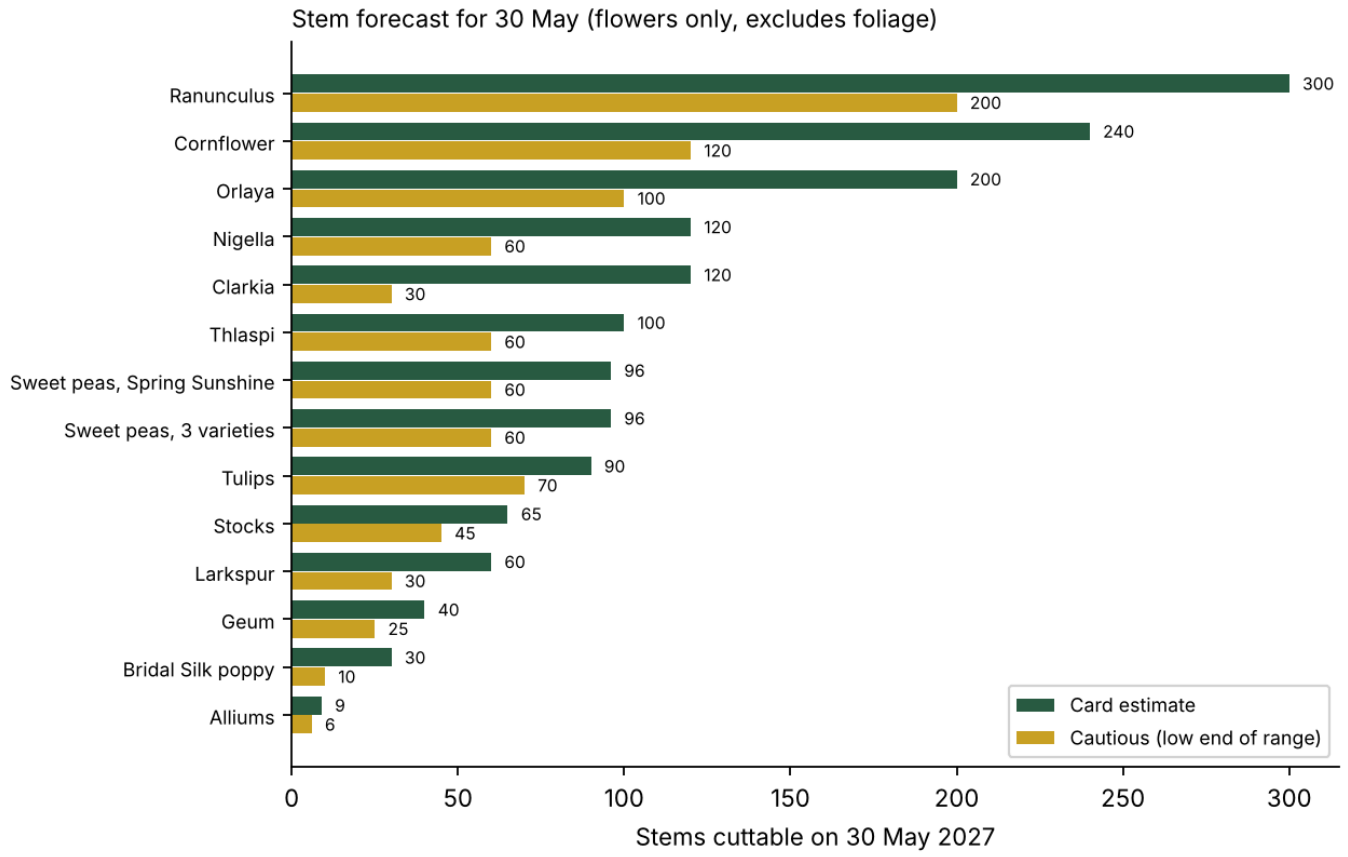
Cold-frame tray ledger (about 18 trays of capacity)

Tray-equivalents are estimates (24 modules, 40 plugs or about 32 root-trainer cells per standard 38 × 24 cm tray), rounded to half a tray. Fullest on about 10 March (17.5 of 18).

In the frame	5 Nov	Dec-Jan	28 Feb	10 Mar	1 Apr	20 Apr	10 May
Sweet peas x74, root trainers (48 for the plot, 26 for home)	2.5	2.5	2.5	2.5	-	-	-
Stocks, batch 1	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.5	-	-	-
Stocks, batch 2 (back-up)	-	-	1	1	1	-	-
Larkspur, clarkia, orlaya	3	3	3	3	-	-	-
Nigella x40, root trainers	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.5	-	-	-
Cornflower x60 and Thlaspi x20	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.5	-	-	-
Bridal Silk poppy x30, root trainers	1	1	1	1	-	-	-
Gambles: Iceland poppy, scabiosa, clary sage	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.5	0.5	-	-
Ranunculus, batch 1 (about 40 corms)	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.5	-	-	-
Ranunculus, batch 2 (about 39 corms)	-	-	1.5	1.5	1.5	-	-
Cabbages (Primo II, Red Kalibo)	-	-	-	1	1	1.5	1.5
Dahlias x7 in 3 L pots	-	-	-	-	2	2	2
Onion seedlings, hardening off	-	-	-	-	1	-	-
Tender plants, hardening off	-	-	-	-	-	3	6
Trays used (of 18)	**14**	**14**	**16.5**	**17.5**	**7**	**6.5**	**9.5**

If the frame fills: drop the gambles first (1.5 trays), then raise Primo II cabbage on a windowsill. Still needs a windowsill or propagator: onions, Didiscus, peppers, eucalyptus, scabiosa main sowing, rudbeckia, statice, lemon bergamot, lavender, tomatoes, helichrysum, basil.

Stem forecast for 30 May



Built from the "Stems on 30 May" line of each plant card (rebuild with `python3 tools/stem_forecast.py`). **Card estimate** is the card's central figure. **Cautious** is the low end of the card's range, and is the figure to plan the wedding on. Foliage is listed separately.

Plant	Plants	Card estimate	Cautious	Confidence	Note
Ranunculus	79	300	200	Medium	3 to 5 stems a plant on the day is the top of the usual range for first-year corms
Cornflower	60	240	120	Medium	Autumn sowing; 4 open stems a plant needs a mild spring
Orlaya	40	200	100	Medium	Good filler; flowers from mid-May
Clarkia	40	120	30	Low	Starts about 25 May, so 30 May is the first day
Nigella	40	120	60	Medium	Seedpods also usable
Thlaspi	20	100	60	Medium	Flowers or green seed discs
Sweet peas, 3 varieties	24	96	60	Medium	24 plants in planter S2, one per cane at 15 cm; 16 more in your garden are a bonus
Sweet peas, Spring Sunshine	24	96	60	Medium	24 plants in planter S1; 10 more in your garden are a bonus. May start earlier
Tulips	105	90	70	High	Pulled with the bulb, so one stem per bulb, minus rodent and rot losses
Stocks	45	65	45	Medium	About 1.5 spikes a plant; batch 2 is the back-up
Larkspur	30	60	30	Low	Starts about 25 May
Geum	5	40	25	Medium	First-year plants, flowering from about 20 May

Plant	Plants	Card estimate	Cautious	Confidence	Note
Bridal Silk poppy	30	30	10	Low	Borderline; June is more likely
Alliums	10	9	6	High	One stem per bulb
Flowers total		**1566**	**876**		
Eucalyptus (foliage)	15	90	20	Low	Planted out 15 to 20 May but cut from 25 May: cut lightly or buy plants (cautious figure assumes this)

Sense check.

The totals are large: about 1,570 stems on the card estimates and about 880 cautious, from roughly 12.5 m² of annuals, 3.2 m² of planters for bulbs and corms, and the sweet pea planters. They are stems cuttable on 30 May, not a season total. The card figures look generous for annuals, so treat the cautious total as the working number.
Late starters: clarkia and larkspur only begin about 25 May and Bridal Silk poppy is borderline. They could give far fewer than the card figures if spring is cool.
Ranunculus is the biggest single line (200 to 300) and the least certain: first-year corms in a crowded planter (13 cm spacing).
Sweet peas (120 to 192 together from 48 plants on the plot): one plant per cane at 15 cm gives each plant room, so stems stay long. Your 26 garden plants are a bonus and are not counted.
Tulips and alliums are the most predictable (one stem per bulb), which is why the early-pull and cold-store plan matters.
Eucalyptus foliage is planted out 15 to 20 May but wanted from 25 May. Cut it lightly or buy larger plants.
Not forecast: scabiosa, Didiscus, Iceland poppies, clary sage, Achillea and Lunaria (all gambles or later), lemon bergamot foliage and mint (no plant count).
What is missing: how many stems the wedding needs. Tell me the list (bouquets, buttonholes, table arrangements, anything else) and I will compare it with these figures by colour and by date.

Countdown to 30 May

Weeks before 30 May	Milestone
30	Sow sweet peas and hardy annuals; plant tulip batch 1 and alliums (29 Oct to 15 Nov)
30	Pot up ranunculus batch 1 (1 to 8 Nov)
21	Plant tulip batch 2 (3 to 10 Jan)
14	Pot up ranunculus batch 2 (20 to 28 Feb)
12	Frame fullest, 17.5 of 18 trays (10 Mar)
12 to 10	Harden off and plant out the autumn-sown annuals and ranunculus batch 1 (5 to 25 Mar)
9 to 8	Plant out sweet peas (25 Mar to 5 Apr)
3	Pull tulip batch 1 (9 to 16 May)
1	Pull tulip batch 2 (20 to 23 May)
0	29 May evening: tulips out of the fridge, re-cut. 30 May: harvest day. 31 May: arrange. 1 June: wedding

Calendar tables by job

Jobs: **Sow** (seed into trays, modules, root trainers or the bed); **Pot up** (move into a bigger pot; corms and tubers go into pots first); **Harden off** (7 to 10 days outdoors by day); **Plant out** (into final bed or planter; for bulbs, plant); **Harvest**. No pot-up row means module to ground. Dates are for mild southern England, plus or minus 1 to 2 weeks. Visual chart: `media/gantt-revised.png`.

Wedding flowers

Plant	Job	Dates	Note
Tulips, batch 1 (about 48 bulbs, planter T)	Plant out	29 Oct–20 Nov	
	Harvest	9 May–16 May	pull with bulb, fridge
Tulips, batch 2 (about 47 bulbs, kept in a tin)	Plant out	3 Jan–10 Jan	
	Harvest	20 May–23 May	pull with bulb, fridge
Ranunculus, batch 1 (about 40 corms)	Pot up	1 Nov–8 Nov	corms into trays
	Harden off	5 Mar–14 Mar	
	Plant out	15 Mar–25 Mar	
	Harvest	25 Apr–25 May	
Ranunculus, batch 2 (about 39 corms)	Pot up	20 Feb–28 Feb	corms into trays
	Harden off	25 Mar–3 Apr	
	Plant out	1 Apr–10 Apr	
	Harvest	15 May–15 Jun	
Allium (late variety) (10 bulbs, all in planter T)	Plant out	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harvest	20 May–10 Jun	
Sweet peas: Muse, Fire & Ice, High Scent (40 sown: 24 in planter S2, 16 to your garden)	Sow	29 Oct–10 Nov	
	Harden off	15 Mar–24 Mar	
	Plant out	25 Mar–5 Apr	
	Harvest	10 May–15 Jul	
Sweet peas: Spring Sunshine (34 sown: 24 in planter S1, 10 to your garden)	Sow	29 Oct–10 Nov	
	Harden off	15 Mar–24 Mar	
	Plant out	25 Mar–5 Apr	

Plant	Job	Dates	Note
	Harvest	10 May–15 Jul	may start earlier
Stocks, batch 1 (3 varieties)	Sow	29 Oct–5 Nov	
	Harden off	5 Mar–14 Mar	
	Plant out	15 Mar–25 Mar	
	Harvest	1 May–10 Jun	
Stocks, batch 2 (back-up)	Sow	15 Feb–28 Feb	
	Harden off	1 Apr–10 Apr	
	Plant out	12 Apr–20 Apr	
	Harvest	20 May–10 Jun	
Larkspur (30 plants)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harden off	5 Mar–14 Mar	
	Plant out	15 Mar–25 Mar	
	Harvest	25 May–30 Jun	
Clarkia (40 plants)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harden off	5 Mar–14 Mar	
	Plant out	15 Mar–25 Mar	
	Harvest	25 May–15 Jul	
Orlaya (40 plants)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harden off	5 Mar–14 Mar	
	Plant out	15 Mar–25 Mar	
	Harvest	15 May–30 Jun	
Nigella (40 plants, root trainers)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harden off	5 Mar–14 Mar	
	Plant out	15 Mar–25 Mar	

Plant	Job	Dates	Note
	Harvest	15 May–15 Jul	
Cornflower (60 plants)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harden off	5 Mar–14 Mar	
	Plant out	15 Mar–25 Mar	
	Harvest	15 May–15 Jul	
Thlaspi (20 plants)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harden off	5 Mar–14 Mar	
	Plant out	15 Mar–25 Mar	
	Harvest	15 Apr–15 Jun	
Poppy Bridal Silk (30 plants, root trainers)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harden off	5 Mar–14 Mar	
	Plant out	15 Mar–25 Mar	seedlings, handle roots gently
	Harvest	25 May–30 Jun	sear stems
Iceland poppies (gamble) (Iceland Giant, Colibri Dolce Vita)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	gamble
	Plant out	15 Mar–31 Mar	
	Harvest	25 May–31 Jul	0 to 1 stem a plant by 30 May
Scabiosa (gamble, then main) (Salmon Queen)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	gamble
	Sow	15 Feb–15 Mar	main sowing, windowsill
	Harden off	1 Apr–14 Apr	
	Plant out	15 Apr–25 Apr	
	Harvest	1 Jun–30 Sep	
Clary sage (check the packet) (Salvia viridis only)	Sow	29 Oct–15 Nov	if S. viridis
	Plant out	15 Mar–31 Mar	
	Harvest	1 Jun–15 Jul	
Didiscus (individual pots, windowsill)	Sow	25 Jan–15 Feb	

Plant	Job	Dates	Note
	Harden off	12 Apr–22 Apr	
	Plant out	23 Apr–30 Apr	
	Harvest	15 Jun–31 Jul	bonus if early
Eucalyptus (foliage) (15 plants)	Sow	10 Feb–25 Feb	
	Pot up	1 Apr–15 Apr	grows 30 cm a week
	Harden off	5 May–14 May	
	Plant out	15 May–20 May	
	Harvest	25 May–31 Jul	
Geum Cosmopolitan (5 plants in 1 L pots)	Plant out	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harvest	20 May–15 Jul	
Achillea The Pearl (buy 1 L plants)	Plant out	15 Apr–15 May	buy plants
	Harvest	1 Jul–31 Aug	few stems at most in May
Lemon bergamot (foliage) (scented green for 30 May)	Sow	15 Feb–15 Mar	
	Harden off	25 Apr–9 May	
	Plant out	10 May–20 May	
	Harvest	25 May–30 Sep	foliage

Other flowers

Plant	Job	Dates	Note
Daffodils (rodent ring round T and R)	Plant out	29 Oct–15 Nov	
	Harvest	1 Mar–30 Apr	stand alone in water first
Dahlias (7 tubers)	Pot up	25 Mar–10 Apr	tubers into 3 L pots
	Harden off	1 May–14 May	
	Plant out	15 May–25 May	
	Harvest	1 Aug–31 Oct	
Marigold Fireball (guard plant)	Sow	15 Mar–15 Apr	
	Harden off	10 May–20 May	
	Plant out	20 May–31 May	
	Harvest	1 Jul–31 Oct	
Candytuft Spangles (brassica block)	Sow	15 Mar–15 May	direct, thin to 15 cm
	Harvest	15 Jun–31 Aug	

Plant	Job	Dates	Note
Rudbeckia	Sow	15 Feb–15 Mar	
	Harden off	1 May–9 May	
	Plant out	10 May–20 May	
	Harvest	1 Jul–31 Oct	
Statice (for drying)	Sow	15 Feb–15 Mar	
	Harden off	10 May–19 May	
	Plant out	20 May–31 May	
	Harvest	1 Jul–30 Sep	
Helichrysum (both) (for drying)	Sow	15 Mar–15 Apr	
	Harden off	10 May–19 May	
	Plant out	20 May–31 May	
	Harvest	1 Jul–30 Sep	
Lunaria (for 2028) (flowers spring 2028)	Sow	1 Jun–15 Jul	
	Plant out	15 Sep–31 Oct	

Veg and fruit

Plant	Job	Dates	Note
Onion Red Herald (clumps of 5)	Sow	15 Jan–15 Feb	
	Harden off	25 Mar–5 Apr	
	Plant out	5 Apr–15 Apr	
	Harvest	1 Aug–30 Sep	
Cabbage Primo II (12 plants)	Sow	1 Mar–15 Mar	
	Harden off	15 Apr–24 Apr	
	Plant out	25 Apr–15 May	
	Harvest	1 Jul–31 Oct	
Cabbage Red Kalibo (8 in planter T)	Sow	1 Apr–10 Apr	
	Pot up	10 May–20 May	optional
	Harden off	25 May–31 May	
	Plant out	1 Jun–15 Jun	
	Harvest	1 Sep–30 Nov	
Carrots (both) (sow in rounds)	Sow	20 Mar–15 Jul	every 3 to 4 weeks
	Harvest	1 Jul–30 Nov	
Beetroot Detroit 2 (sow in rounds)	Sow	25 Mar–15 Jul	every 3 weeks
	Harvest	15 Jun–31 Oct	
Tomatoes (both) (Buffalosteak, Toddler)	Sow	10 Mar–25 Mar	
	Pot up	10 Apr–25 Apr	
	Harden off	15 May–24 May	
	Plant out	25 May–10 Jun	
	Harvest	1 Jul–15 Oct	
Peppers (both) (sweet, Snackbite)	Sow	15 Feb–5 Mar	

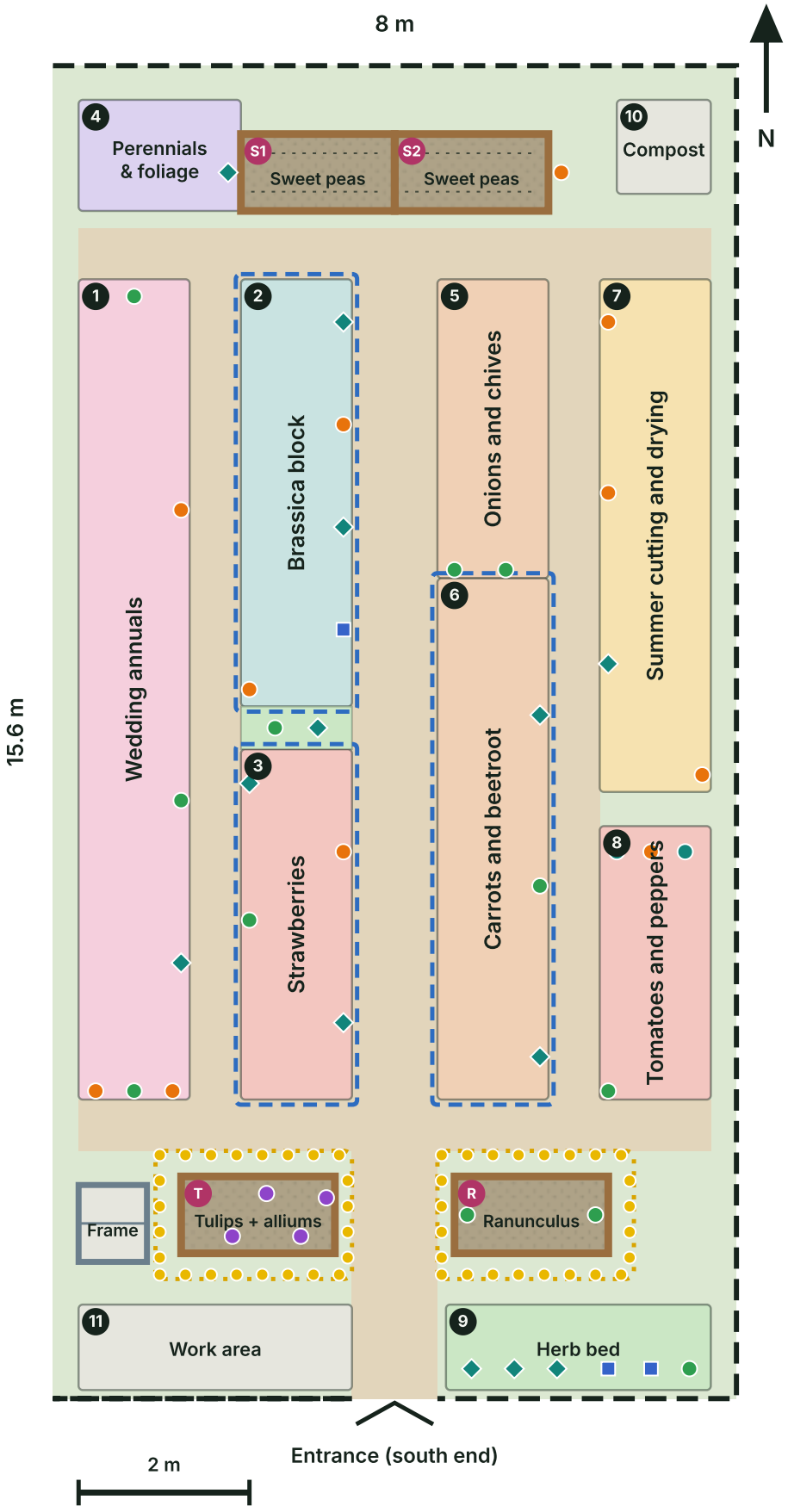
Plant	Job	Dates	Note
	Pot up	1 Apr–20 Apr	
	Harden off	25 May–4 Jun	
	Plant out	5 Jun–15 Jun	
	Harvest	1 Aug–31 Oct	
Strawberry Fenella (20 plants arrive in March)	Plant out	1 Mar–31 Mar	
	Harvest	1 Jun–31 Jul	small crop in year 1

Herbs (guard plants)

Plant	Job	Dates	Note
Chives (buy or divide for early guard)	Sow	1 Mar–15 Apr	
	Plant out	15 Apr–31 May	
	Harvest	15 May–31 Oct	
Thyme	Sow	1 Mar–15 Apr	
	Plant out	15 Apr–31 May	or buy a pot plant
	Harvest	1 Jun–31 Oct	
Mint and applemint (sunk pots only)	Plant out	15 Mar–30 Apr	plants or divisions
	Harvest	1 May–31 Oct	
Rosemary (buy a plant in April)	Plant out	15 Apr–15 May	buy plants
	Harvest	1 Jun–31 Oct	
Lavender (first flowers 2028)	Sow	15 Feb–15 Mar	
	Plant out	15 May–15 Jun	
Basil (tomato bed)	Sow	20 Apr–10 May	
	Pot up	15 May–5 Jun	prick out
	Harden off	5 Jun–14 Jun	
	Plant out	15 Jun–25 Jun	
	Harvest	1 Jul–30 Sep	

Part 4. Plot plan and rotation

Plot layout



Assumptions: **there is no gate (the plot has no physical boundaries), so the south end, where the main path starts, is treated as the entrance**. Tall things at the north; tulip and ranunculus planters nearest the entrance; the brassica family in one block; carrots beside onions; compost in the far corner from the bulbs. Paths: main path 1 m, side paths 0.6 m, wood chip over cardboard; a 0.3 m mown edge strip. Hatched blue outlines on the drawing are insect mesh or net on hoops.

Of the 125 m², the beds below total about 60 m² and the planters 6.5 m². The old budget of 95 m² of beds was generous for the plant numbers.

Perimeter is the length of edge round each bed (2 x (width + length)). Use it to price edging boards, mesh skirts or netting. Bed dimensions are taken from the drawing: confirm them on the ground before you buy.

Bed	m2	Perimeter m	What goes in	Why here
1 Wedding annuals	12.5	21.8	Larkspur, clarkia, orlaya, nigella, cornflower and Bridal Silk poppy at about 20 cm. Eucalyptus ×15 across the north end. Didiscus at the south end.	The wedding crop gets the best strip. It is also furthest from the carrots (orlaya and Didiscus are carrot family).
2 Brassica block	6.5	12.6	Stocks (3 varieties) and Thlaspi, then candytuft and Primo II cabbage. Insect mesh on hoops.	Stocks, Thlaspi, candytuft and cabbage share clubroot and flea beetle, so they stay in one block that moves each year.
3 Strawberries	5.3	10.8	20 Fenella in two staggered rows, net frame over the top.	Away from the geum (bed 4) and held off the brassicas by the guard strip.
4 Perennials & foliage	2.5	6.4	Geum ×5, achillea, clary sage, lemon bergamot.	Permanent bed in a corner, so it is never dug. North side, so it shades nothing.
5 Onions and chives	4.5	9.6	Red Herald onion clumps at 25 cm, chives along the south end.	Directly against the carrot bed: the onion smell masks the carrot smell.
6 Carrots and beetroot	7.9	14.8	Carrots in rounds, beetroot between. 80 cm insect mesh round the carrots.	Stone-free, unmanured, a metre or more from orlaya and Didiscus.
7 Summer cutting and drying	7.8	14.6	Dahlias ×7, rudbeckia, statice, helichrysum, scabiosa, marigolds between.	Planted after the last frost. Tall dahlias at the north.
8 Tomatoes and peppers	4.2	9.0	Buffalosteak and Toddler tomatoes, two peppers, basil and marigold.	South end: the warmest, sunniest spot, close to the entrance for picking.
9 Herb bed	3.1	8.2	Rosemary, thyme, lavender, chives, mint and applemint in sunk pots (kept apart).	By the entrance for picking. Cuttings and divisions from here feed the guard strips.
10 Compost	1.2	4.4	Two closed bins with a mesh base.	The far corner from the bulb planters. Open heaps feed rats.
11 Work area	3.2	8.4	Potting bench, water butt, tool box, boards stood 30 cm off the ground.	Next to the cold frame. Keep it tidy: stacked timber and old sacks shelter mice.
T, R planters	1.6 each	5.4 each	See Raised planters below. Daffodil ring around each.	Nearest the entrance; rodents avoid ground people cross
S1, S2 planters	1.6 each	5.4 each	Sweet peas, 24 per planter (S1 Spring Sunshine, S2 the other three varieties)	North edge; the main path leads straight to them, so damage shows quickly

Bed	m2	Perimeter m	What goes in	Why here
Cold frame	0.7	3.4	18 trays, 6 mm mesh floor, mesh over vents	South-west of the entrance beside the planters

Next year the brassica block moves (to bed 1) and the wedding annuals move to bed 2's ground (see rotation below).

Guard plants

Guard	Beside	Notes
Daffodils, alliums	Tulip and ranunculus planters	Strongest effect on the plot. Daffodils every 15 cm in the ring, 10 to 15 cm deep.
Chives	Carrots, strawberries, ranunculus, brassica guard strip	Never within a metre of sweet peas. Fleece in Oct-Nov and Mar-Apr (leaf miner).
Thyme, rosemary, sage	Cabbages, carrots, strawberries, sweet pea ends	Partial effect on egg-laying butterflies.
Mint, applemint	Beside the brassica block	Sunk pots only, never side by side (they hybridise).
Marigold 'Fireball'	Brassicas, tomatoes, dahlias, planters after May	Hoverflies eat aphids. Plant out after the last frost.
Basil	Tomatoes and peppers	Plant out mid-June.
Nigella, orlaya, cornflower	Sweet peas and stocks	Feed hoverflies and lacewings; also wedding flowers.

Companion effects are modest; mesh and netting do the heavy lifting.

Raised planters

4 in total (2 minimum), 1 needed immediately, 0 extenders. Planter size 180 × 90 cm (1.6 m2). Assumed: no base, at least 25 cm deep.

Planter	Buy by	Holds	Guards mixed in	After the wedding
T: tulips	Now (plant by about 20 Nov)	105 tulips (95 plus 10 insurance) at about 8 x 10 cm. Batch 1 in one half now, batch 2 in the other half in January. About 25 alliums between them.	Alliums; daffodils in the corners and in the ground ring around the planter	June: 8 'Red Kalibo' cabbages with marigolds
R: ranunculus	Mid-February (plant out 15 Mar)	All 79 corms at about 13 cm. Batch 1 first, batch 2 in early April.	Chives at both ends, thyme at the corners; marigolds once the first corms finish	June: late carrots and beetroot under insect mesh
S1 + S2: sweet peas	Mid-March (plant out 25 Mar)	48 plants, one per cane every 15 cm: S1 holds 24 Spring Sunshine, S2 holds 24 of the other three varieties, each in two rows of 1.8 m (12 canes a row, 2.4 m canes). The other 26 sown plants go to your garden.	Nigella, cornflower, orlaya underneath; marigold or thyme at the ends. No chives or onions within a metre.	Pull in late July; green manure or winter salads

Why this order: tulips are the most dug-up crop and cannot wait. Ranunculus and sweet peas live in the cold frame until March (74 sweet peas are sown; 48 go on the plot, 26 to your garden).
Money-tight route: buy T now and R in February. Plant the 48 plot sweet peas in a compost-enriched trench at the north end, in two rows with one plant per cane, with 6 mm mesh collars until May.

Extenders: skip. In a planter the mesh lid protects tulips, so plant them at 10 to 15 cm (open ground: 15 to 20 cm). Ranunculus 3 cm. Sweet peas are fine in 25 cm. Only a planter shallower than about 20 cm justifies one.
Build: lay 6 mm galvanised mesh on the ground, 30 cm wider than the planter all round, and set the planter on it. Fold it up the inside walls 15 to 20 cm and fix it. Overlap joins by 10 cm and wire them. About 3 m2 of mesh per planter. Fill with about half topsoil from the plot, a third compost and the rest grit (about 0.5 m3 per planter at 30 cm). For T and R lay a mesh lid flat over the bed straight after planting, pegged every 20 cm; 25 mm stops squirrels, finer also stops mice but shoots must still push through. Remove it at about 10 cm of growth.

Succession: where space is reused

After the early-pulled tulips and the faded ranunculus clear in June, planter T becomes the home for **'Red Kalibo' cabbage** (8 plants, with marigolds), planted from modules 1-15 June, and planter R takes a late sowing of **carrots and beetroot** (mid-June to mid-July) under insect mesh. Feed with compost first because cabbage is a hungry crop after bulbs.

Rotation by plant family and bed

Year 2 (2028) moves: the brassica block (bed 2) moves to bed 1's ground, and the wedding annuals (bed 1) move to bed 2's ground. Onions and chives (bed 5) swap with carrots and beetroot (bed 6) only if the onion bed has had white rot; otherwise swap onions with tomatoes (bed 8). Summer cutting (bed 7) and tomatoes (bed 8) swap places. Beds 4 and 9 (perennials and herbs) and the planters stay put. Keep orlaya and Didiscus (carrot family) at least a metre from carrots in every year.

Crops in the same family share pests and diseases, so they travel together and never follow themselves in the same soil.

Family	On your list	Rule
Brassicaceae (cabbage family)	Cabbage ×2, stocks ×3, Thlaspi, Lunaria, candytuft	Keep in one block. Clubroot lives in soil for up to 20 years. Never follow brassicas with brassicas. Use flea-beetle mesh
Amaryllidaceae (onion family)	Onion, chives, allium	Onion white rot persists. Rotate. Use fleece against allium leaf miner in Oct–Nov and Mar–Apr
Apiaceae (carrot family)	Carrots ×2, orlaya, Didiscus	Orlaya and Didiscus are not carrot-fly hosts, but keep them separated from the carrot bed as a precaution
Solanaceae	Tomatoes ×2, peppers ×2	No potatoes nearby (blight). New bed each year
Asteraceae (daisy family)	Dahlias, rudbeckia, marigold, helichrysum, cornflower, achillea	Slugs and aphids favour these. Mix with aromatic herbs
Ranunculaceae	Ranunculus, larkspur, nigella	Rotate cut-flower beds yearly
Papaveraceae	Poppies ×3	Self-sow freely. Do not disturb roots
Lamiaceae (mint family)	Herbs, lavender, clary sage, lemon bergamot	Mints spread. Contain them
Rosaceae	Strawberry, geum	Vine weevil risk across both. Inspect pots on arrival

Design rules I used

Rodent-attractive plants live in the most-visited, most-fenced places: the tulip and ranunculus planters (T, R) sit nearest the entrance, and the sweet pea planters (S1, S2) at the end of the main path, so damage shows quickly. Tulips and sweet peas are the likely targets.

Daffodils and alliums ring planters T and R. Mice, voles and squirrels avoid them, so they act as a living border.

Tall to the north, short to the south so nothing shades the cutting beds.

Aromatic herbs at the edges of vegetable beds to confuse pests. This reduces damage but does not replace netting.

Marigold and nigella throughout as hoverfly magnets, because hoverfly larvae eat aphids.

No bare soil. Mulch with compost or leaf mould so weeds do not move in. Do not rely on ground cover to keep slugs out: it can shelter them. (Undersowing means sowing a low, quick-growing cover plant, such as clover, among or beneath a taller crop that is already growing, so the soil is never bare. For the wedding beds a compost mulch does the same job without competing for water.)

Part 5. Vermin and pest defence plan

Mice, voles, squirrels and pigeons are the four things most likely to cost you flowers before 30 May. The defence has four layers, and each is already built into the layout in Part 4: (1) do not feed or house them, (2) make the plants physically unreachable, (3) put the tastiest plants where they are watched and fenced, (4) monitor and trap.

Who eats what

Threat	Targets on your list	Peak risk	Main defence
Mice and voles	Tulip and ranunculus bulbs/corms, sweet pea and poppy seed, stored bulbs, strawberries	Oct–Mar, then Jun–Jul for fruit	Wire mesh over beds, mouse-proof frame, snap traps in tunnels, no hiding places
Grey squirrels	Newly planted tulip bulbs, sweet pea seedlings, strawberries	Oct–Dec, spring	Mesh lid pegged flat over bulbs, plant 10–15 cm deep in planters (15–20 cm in open ground)
Rats	Anything near compost, spilled seed or food waste. Chew through plastic netting	All year	Tidy plot, no food waste, closed compost bin, tell the site rep, traps
Wood pigeons	Cabbage, young sweet peas, brassica seedlings, stocks	Autumn–spring	Net on hoops over brassicas and seed beds
Slugs and snails	Ranunculus shoots, dahlias, sweet peas, beetroot, cabbage seedlings, stocks	Mar–Jun, and mild autumn nights	Nematodes from March, night patrols, raised seedlings, spare plants
Carrot fly	Carrots	May–Jun, Aug–Sep	Mesh barrier 60–80 cm high, thin sowing, never thin in daytime
Cabbage white caterpillars, root fly	Both cabbages, stocks	May–Sep	Insect mesh (1.3 mm or finer) on hoops, root-fly collars
Flea beetle	Stocks, Thlaspi, Lunaria, candytuft, cabbage seedlings	Apr–Jun	Fine mesh (0.8 mm) or fleece, keep seedlings watered
Allium leaf miner, onion fly	Onions, chives, allium	Oct–Nov and Mar–Apr (miner), Apr–Jun (fly)	Fleece or fine mesh in those windows
Aphids	Sweet peas, stocks, dahlias, cabbages	Apr–Jul	Hoverfly flowers (nigella, orlaya, marigold), squirt off, soft soap
Birds	Strawberries, ripening peppers, seedlings	May–Jul	Netted frame over strawberries
Blight	Tomatoes	Jul–Sep	Space plants, strip lower leaves, rain cover if you can

Layer 1. Do not feed or house them

Store bulbs in a lidded metal tin or thick plastic box, never a paper bag on a shelf. This matters most for the second batch of tulips waiting until January. Keep them somewhere cool (5–9°C), dry and away from fruit, and check them weekly for mould.

Never leave seed or bulbs loose. Sow all sweet pea and poppy seed into containers you can cover, never straight into open ground.

Remove hiding places. Pallets, old carpet, plastic sheeting, stacked timber and long grass beside beds shelter mice. Stand stored items 30 cm off the ground and keep path edges short.

Compost carefully. Use an enclosed bin with a mesh base. Never add cooked food, bread, meat or dairy. Open heaps feed rats.

No bird feeders. Spilled seed brings both rats and mice.

Pick up windfalls and ripe fruit daily, especially strawberries.

Layer 2. Make the plants unreachable

Planters T and R (bulbs and corms): the planters have no base, so build the mesh in from the start: lay 6 mm galvanised mesh on the ground, 30 cm wider than the planter all round, set the planter on it, and fold the mesh up the inside walls 15–20 cm and fix it. Overlap joins by 10 cm and wire them (about 3 m² of mesh per planter). Then, straight after planting, lay a mesh lid flat over the whole bed. 25 mm mesh stops squirrels; finer (6 mm) also stops mice but shoots must be able to grow through it, so remove a fine lid once shoots are 10 cm tall. In open ground (any bulbs planted outside the planters), after planting, lay 25 mm galvanised wire mesh flat over the whole bed and peg it every 20 cm with an extra 15 cm skirt turned down at the edges. Shoots grow through the holes. Leave it on until growth is 10 cm tall, then remove it or leave it if it does not restrict leaves. Mesh as fine as 6 mm stops mice from squeezing through, but squirrels are stopped by 25 mm.

Plant deep: tulips 15–20 cm in open ground (your note says 6–10 inches, which matches). In a 25 cm deep planter plant at 10–15 cm: the mesh base and lid do the protecting, and a 15–20 cm hole would leave too little soil below the bulb. Ranunculus corms go only 3 cm deep. Squirrels rarely dig below 10 cm.

Grit helps drainage, not rodents: 3 cm of coarse grit around each bulb prevents rot in deep planting but does not deter animals on its own.

Chilli or capsaicin powders give a short-term deterrent only. Rain washes them off, so treat them as an extra and not the main defence.

Sweet pea and poppy seed: sow into root trainers or modules, put the trays in the cold frame, and cover each tray with mesh as well. Plant out as seedlings. Sweet peas (48 on the plot, 24 in each of S1 and S2) go into the planters in late March (a mesh base like T and R); the rest go to your garden; if you cannot afford S1 and S2 yet, plant them in a compost-enriched trench at the north end with 6 mm mesh collars until May.

Cold frame: line the base with 6 mm mesh, close every gap, and cover vent gaps with a mesh strip.

Strawberries: net the whole bed on a frame, with mesh down to the soil and pegged.

Brassicas: insect mesh on hoops, fixed to the soil all round with timber or pegs, from the day of planting.

Layer 3. Put the tastiest plants where you walk

Planters T and R (bulbs and corms) sit nearest the entrance, next to the cold frame. Rodents avoid beds they pass often.

A daffodil ring around planters T and R. Plant daffodils every 15 cm along the border, 10–15 cm deep. Mice, voles and squirrels leave daffodils and alliums alone because they are toxic, so these bulbs act as a living fence. Alliums are the same.

Sweet peas (planters S1 and S2) at the north end of the main path, so the path leads straight to them and damage is noticed in days.

Keep beds apart with short, mown paths so rodents must cross open ground to reach them.

How to apply fleece

Choose the weight. 17 gsm keeps out insects and gives about 1–2 °C of frost protection. 30 gsm gives about 3–4 °C.

Drape loosely. Leave slack for growth, or lift it on hoops 40–60 cm high so it never rests on wet foliage (ranunculus, sweet peas).

Seal every edge. Bury it, or weigh it with soil, pegs, bricks or boards. Overlap joins by 15 cm. Gaps defeat both frost and insect protection.

For frost: on at dusk, off on mild days (above about 5 °C) so plants can ventilate and do not go mouldy. Use a double layer in hard frost. In the cold frame, lay it directly over the trays under the lid.

For insects (allium leaf miner in Oct–Nov and Mar–Apr, flea beetle on brassicas): fit it at planting, sealed all round, and leave it on through the risk window.

Layer 4. Monitor and trap

Weekly patrol (5 minutes): look for 2–3 cm tunnel holes (mice and voles), 5–8 cm holes (rats), gnawed stems, pulled-up bulbs and droppings.

Snap traps in covered tunnels. Use a plank or a length of pipe so no birds or hedgehogs can reach them. Put 6 along fence lines and path edges. Bait with peanut butter or chocolate spread. Set at dusk, check every morning.

Rats: tell the site representative. Many allotment sites prohibit poison for good reason, because it harms owls, foxes and hedgehogs. Use traps in locked boxes.

Insurance: keep roughly 15% more tulip and ranunculus plants than you strictly need. The second tulip batch in January is also your reserve.

Companion planting for pest control (honest evidence note)

Companion effects are modest and netting does the heavy lifting. These pairings are still worth using because they cost nothing.

Pairing	What it does
Nigella, orlaya and marigold beside brassicas, stocks and sweet peas	Flowers feed hoverflies and lacewings, whose larvae eat aphids
Onion and chives next to carrots	Strong scent masks the carrot smell from carrot fly (partial effect)

Pairing	What it does
Rosemary, thyme and sage beside cabbages	Scent may confuse egg-laying butterflies (partial effect)
French marigolds with tomatoes	May deter whitefly. Also attracts hoverflies
Basil with tomatoes and peppers	Scent confuses some insects, and the two ripen in the same conditions
Daffodils and alliums around bulb beds	Rodent-proof border (strong effect)
Mint in sunken pots near cabbages	May deter cabbage white butterflies (partial effect). Never plant mint loose

Part 6. Cut-flower handling

Harvest-day plan: Sunday 30 May 2027

Cut early (before 8 am) or in the evening. Flowers are full of water then.
Prepare clean buckets. Wash with dilute bleach (or Milton) and fill with 15–20 cm of cool, clean water and flower food.
Cut at an angle with clean, sharp snips. Strip leaves that would sit below the waterline.
Plunge straight into water. Do not leave stems on the grass for more than seconds.
Condition for 12–24 hours in a cool, dark, draught-free place (garage, 8–12°C), away from fruit, which gives off ethylene.
Mon 31 May (bank holiday): re-cut, sort by variety and stem length, arrange or box.
Tue 1 June: wedding.

Stage to cut, treatment and vase life

Flower	Cut when	Treat	Cold store at 2–4°C	Vase life
Tulip	Coloured bud, still closed (for storage)	Pull with bulb, trim bulb off after, wrap dry in newspaper, rehydrate 12–24 h	2–3 weeks dry-wrapped	5–7 days
Ranunculus	"Marshmallow" stage: bud soft when squeezed, colour showing	Re-cut every day	5–7 days in water	5–7 days
Sweet peas	Lowest 2–3 flowers open	Cool water, no fruit nearby	2–3 days	3–5 days
Stocks	One-third to half open	Strip leaves, change water daily (stems smell)	5–7 days	7–10 days
Allium	Half to three-quarters open	Rinse and re-cut to reduce oniony smell	Up to 1 week	7–14 days
Larkspur	One-third of the spike open	Keep away from fruit (shatters)	Up to 1 week	5–7 days
Clarkia	Lower 3–4 flowers open	Strip leaves	3–4 days	5–7 days
Orlaya	Half the florets open	None	3–5 days	5–7 days
Nigella	First flower open	Seed pods last weeks	2–3 days	4–5 days
Cornflower	Half open	Strip lower leaves	3–4 days	5–7 days
Poppy 'Bridal Silk'	Bud cracking, colour showing	Sear: dip 2–3 cm of stem end in just-boiled water for 5–10 seconds, then cold water	1–2 days	2–4 days
Geum	First flowers opening	Plain water	3–4 days	5–7 days
Thlaspi	Flowers or green seed discs	None	5–7 days	7–10 days
Eucalyptus	Any time	Strip lower leaves, split woody ends	1–2 weeks	2+ weeks
Daffodil	Gooseneck stage	Stand alone in water for 12–24 h first: sap harms other flowers	3–4 days	4–7 days

Extending, shifting or rescuing the bloom window

If flowers are...	Do this
Too early (open before 30 May)	Cut at bud stage and cold-store at 2–4°C. Shade plants with 30% shade cloth. Cut in the evening and chill overnight. Tulips: pull earlier and dry-store. Ranunculus: store in water
Too late (not open by 30 May)	Cover beds with a cloche or fleece from mid-April (brings bloom forward 5–7 days). Cut tight buds and open them in warm water indoors: stocks, ranunculus, larkspur and sweet peas open in 1–3 days at 20°C
Finishing mid-bloom	Pick off spent flowers to prolong flowering. Feed with high-potash tomato feed every 10 days. Water deeply. Succession sowings take over
Frost forecast in spring	Cover with double fleece. Take in potted ranunculus. Tulips cope to about −5°C
Wind or heavy rain forecast	Cut ready stems early, store cold, and support tall stems with netting

Keep stems fresh longer

Re-cut 2 cm every 2 days and change water.

Keep away from fruit bowls and radiators.

Use flower food, or a pinch of sugar and 2 drops of bleach per litre.

A cool room (below 15°C) doubles most vase lives.

Part 7. Plant cards

Every plant has one card with the same rows in the same order, so you can find what you need without reading. Cards run in four groups: wedding flowers, other flowers, vegetables and fruit, herbs. Spacing is centre to centre. "Stems on 30 May" assumes the target plant numbers given on each card and normal losses. Beds are numbered 1 to 11 and planters are T, R, S1 and S2 (Part 4). Dates for hardening off are in the calendar tables in Part 3.

A. Wedding flowers

Tulips: 'Light up the Shade' ×40, 'Shells on the Beach' ×20, 'Mount Tacoma' ×25, 'Beachberry' ×10

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track with early pull and cold store. Bulb. Perennial in theory, but you pull the bulb with the stem, so treat as annual
Sow / plant	Batch 1 (half of each variety, about 48 bulbs): 29 Oct to 20 Nov, pointed end up, in planter T, 10–15 cm deep (the planter is 25 cm deep; use 15–20 cm only in open ground). Batch 2 (the rest, about 47): 3–10 January, same depth, in the other half of planter T. Store batch 2 at 5–9°C in a lidded tin until then. Cold soil lowers the risk of tulip fire
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Not applicable
Plant out / space	Plant in final position, planter T: 105 bulbs (95 plus 10 insurance) at about 8 × 10 cm, with your 10 alliums between them. In open ground use a bed with sharp drainage (add 3 cm grit around bulbs on clay)
Support	None. Late doubles ('Mount Tacoma', 'Beachberry') have heavy heads: one layer of netting at 30 cm if the site is windy
Protect	Mesh base and sides on planter T, and a mesh lid pegged flat over the bed from planting until shoots reach 10 cm (Part 5). Slug patrol in March. Burn or bin any plant with grey mould spots
Pair with	Daffodils and alliums as a rodent-proof border. Ranunculus in the next rows
Keep away from	Soil where tulips grew in the last 3 years (tulip fire). Wet, shaded ground
Back-up plan	Your half-now, half-January split. The 10 extra bulbs in planter T are the insurance. If both batches lose more than 20%, buy potted tulips in April for filler
Harvest: when	Batch 1 about 9–16 May. Batch 2 about 20–23 May. Pull when buds are fully coloured but still closed and firm. If a warm spell arrives, pull early. Late doubles can wait until 20 May
Harvest: how	Pull the whole plant with the bulb: this gives the longest stem. Trim off the bulb. No water. Wrap 10–20 stems tightly in newspaper, tie, store in the fridge at 2–4°C (away from fruit and veg), upright if you can. On 29–30 May re-cut 2 cm and stand in cold water for 12–24 hours in a tight bunch. Your note says 18–20 hours, which is fine
Stems on 30 May	One per bulb. About 90 from 105 bulbs (95 plus 10 insurance; range 70–100) after rodents and rot

Ranunculus: 'Butterfly' ×3, 'Amandine Pastel Pink' ×25, pink ×50, R. asiaticus ×1

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track. Corm. Tender perennial: lift or treat as annual
Sow / plant	Batch 1 (about 40): soak corms in cool water for 3–4 hours only (longer rots them), then plant claws-down 3 cm deep in trays or pots of gritty compost (pot up 1–8 November), in the cold frame. Batch 2 (about 39): same method, late February. Keep just moist

Field	Plan
Pot up	1–8 November (batch 1) and 20–28 February (batch 2): corms into trays or pots of gritty compost. Then straight to planter R
Pinch out	Not applicable
Plant out / space	Batch 1: 15–25 March. Batch 2: 1–10 April, after hardening off. Planter R, all 79 corms at about 13 cm (tighter than the usual 15–20 cm because they are cut heavily; a 3 cm planting depth is fine in a 25 cm planter). Sun, free-draining, pH 6–7
Support	One layer of netting at 30 cm if windy
Protect	Mesh base and sides on planter R, and a mesh lid after planting (mice love corms). Fleece below −3°C. Nematodes from March for slugs. Good air flow against mildew. Never let them stand wet
Pair with	Tulips in the next rows. Stocks and daffodil border
Keep away from	Waterlogged clay and deep shade
Back-up plan	Batch 2 is the back-up for batch 1. Buy 20 potted ranunculus in March if corms fail. Keep 10 spare corms
Harvest: when	Batch 1 peaks 25 Apr–25 May. Batch 2 peaks 15 May–15 Jun. Pick at "marshmallow" stage: bud fat and soft, colour showing, petals just starting to loosen
Harvest: how	Cut long stems at an angle. Pick every 2–3 days to keep flowers coming. Stand in cool water for 6–12 hours. Store 5–7 days in water in the fridge
Stems on 30 May	3–5 per plant on the day (10–20 across the season). About 300 from 79 corms (range 200–450)

Allium (variety not stated)

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track if a late-flowering variety. Bulb. Perennial
Sow / plant	29 Oct to mid-Nov, 10–15 cm deep (3× bulb height), pointed end up. You have 10 bulbs: all in planter T between the tulips (buy more only if you want a ground ring; daffodils already ring the planters)
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Not applicable
Plant out / space	Final position. About 20 cm apart (planter T holds 105 tulips and 10 alliums), full sun, free-draining
Support	None for stems under 90 cm. Tall ones: link stakes with string
Protect	Rodent-proof (toxic to them). Fleece or fine mesh in Oct–Nov and Mar–Apr against allium leaf miner
Pair with	Tulips, daffodils, geum. Carrots in a nearby bed
Keep away from	Peas, beans and sweet peas (folk wisdom, mild effect). Soil where onions had white rot
Back-up plan	If bulbs fail, buy potted alliums in April or use thistle-like Eryngium if you can source it
Harvest: when	About 20 May to 10 Jun, when half to three-quarters open
Harvest: how	Cut at the base. Rinse stems and re-cut to reduce the oniony smell. Condition in cool water. Seedheads dry for later
Stems on 30 May	One per bulb. About 9 from 10 bulbs

Stocks: 'Antique Rose', 'Champagne', 'White' (suggest 15 plants each)

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track with Feb back-up. Half-hardy annual, brassica family. Not perennial
Sow / plant	Batch 1: 29 Oct–5 Nov. Surface-sow in 24-cell trays, barely cover, cold frame, germinates in 7–14 days. Batch 2: mid to late Feb, same method, on a windowsill or in the frame
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Do not pinch single-stem column types
Plant out / space	Batch 1: mid-March. Batch 2: mid-April. 20–25 cm apart, firm and limey soil (pH 6.5–7.5), full sun
Support	One layer of netting at 30–40 cm
Protect	Fine mesh against flea beetle and pigeons. Slug patrol. Clubroot risk: grow in a brassica-family block (Part 4)
Pair with	Nigella, orlaya, marigold (hoverflies). Ranunculus
Keep away from	Tomatoes and strawberries (folk wisdom). Soil that grew brassicas in the last 3–4 years
Back-up plan	Batch 2 in February. If both fail, buy plugs in April
Harvest: when	About 1 May to 10 Jun, when one-third to half of the spike is open
Harvest: how	Cut at ground level, strip all leaves, change water daily (stems smell). Vase 7–10 days
Stems on 30 May	About 1.5 per plant. About 65 from 45 plants (range 45–90)

Sweet peas ×40: 'Muse', 'Fire & Ice', 'High Scent' (together with 'Spring Sunshine' ×34 below, 74 sown in all; 48 go on the plot)

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track. Hardy annual, legume. Not perennial
Sow / plant	Now (29 Oct–10 Nov): 1 seed per root trainer, 2.5 cm deep, in the cold frame under mesh. Soak overnight to speed germination. Germinates in 10–14 days. All 74 sweet peas are sown now: there is no January sowing. The extra plants cover failures and go to your garden
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 2–3 pairs of true leaves (about 10 cm, in Dec–Jan), pinch above the pair. Choose 2–3 strong shoots per plant
Plant out / space	Harden off 15–24 March, plant out 25 March–5 April into planter S2: the best 24 plants. The other 16 go to your garden. One plant per cane, a cane every 15 cm, so each plant has room (Part 4). Sun, pH 6.5–7. A 25 cm planter is deep enough for sweet peas
Support	Planter S2 (1.8 m long) takes two rows of 2.4 m canes, 45 cm apart, 12 canes a row (24 canes), with string or netting. Grow each plant as a single-stem cordon: tie in weekly, remove tendrils and side shoots
Protect	Mesh base on S2 (or 6 mm mesh collars in a trench if the planters are not yet bought). Slug patrol. Fleece in late frost. Aphids: squirt off
Pair with	Nigella, cornflower and orlaya below the rows. Marigold or thyme at the ends
Keep away from	Onions, garlic, chives within a metre (folk wisdom). S2 is at the north end, away from bed 5
Back-up plan	Plug plants in March as a rescue. If germination is poor, a January sowing flowers 2–3 weeks later
Harvest: when	From about 10 May to mid-July. Cut when the lowest 2–3 flowers are open

Field	Plan
Harvest: how	Cut long stems, pick every 2–3 days so plants keep producing, cool water at once. Store 2–3 days in a cool room, away from fruit
Stems on 30 May	3–5 per plant. About 96 from the 24 plants on the plot (range 60–144). The 16 plants in your garden are a bonus

Sweet peas ×34: 'Spring Sunshine' (24 on the plot, 10 for your garden)

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track. Hardy annual, legume. Assumed to be seed. An early-flowering series (one supplier lists "very early flowering", April to June, for the mix; the UK supplier gives no flowering date)
Sow / plant	Same as the other sweet peas: 29 Oct–10 Nov, 1 seed per root trainer, 2.5 cm deep, in the frame under mesh. Suppliers give 14–21 days to germinate. Check the packet for sowing advice
Pinch out	At 2–3 pairs of true leaves (Dec–Jan)
Pot up	Not applicable (root trainer to planter)
Plant out / space	Harden off 15–24 March, plant out 25 March–5 April into planter S1: the best 24 plants, one per cane every 15 cm. The other 10 go to your garden
Support	As the other sweet peas
Protect	As the other sweet peas
Pair with	Nigella, cornflower and orlaya below the rows
Keep away from	Onions, garlic and chives (within a metre)
Back-up plan	If they are not seed but plants, plant them out at the same time and skip the sowing
Harvest: when	May be a little earlier than the other sweet peas. Plan from about 10 May to mid-July. Cut when the lowest 2–3 flowers are open
Harvest: how	As the other sweet peas
Stems on 30 May	3–5 per plant. About 96 from the 24 plants on the plot (range 60–144). Combined with the first card: about 192 from 48 plants on the plot (range 120–288), plus your garden

Larkspur 'Pretty Pink' (suggest 30 plants)

Field	Plan
At a glance	⚠ Borderline: autumn-sown larkspur starts around late May. Hardy annual. Toxic. Not perennial
Sow / plant	29 Oct–15 Nov in cell trays, 5 mm deep, kept cool and dark (10–15°C). Germinates in 2–3 weeks
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Optional: pinch once at 15 cm in March for 4–6 stems per plant, though the main spike is smaller
Plant out / space	Mid-March, 20–25 cm apart. Sun, fertile soil
Support	Two layers of netting at 50 cm and 90 cm. Stems reach 90–120 cm
Protect	Slug patrol. Mesh against pigeons while small
Pair with	Orlaya, nigella, cornflower, clarkia
Keep away from	Salad beds (all parts are toxic). Wear gloves
Back-up plan	Spring sowing misses the wedding. Instead buy 20 plugs in March, and plant them behind the autumn batch
Harvest: when	From about 25 May. Cut when one-third of the spike is open
Harvest: how	Early morning, long stems, plunge in water. Keep away from fruit (flowers drop). Vase 5–7 days

Field	Plan
Stems on 30 May	1–2 per plant at the start of flowering. About 60 from 30 plants (range 30–110)

Clarkia 'May Blossom' (suggest 40 plants)

Field	Plan
At a glance	⚠ Borderline: starts late May. Hardy annual. Not perennial
Sow / plant	29 Oct–15 Nov, surface-sow in modules, barely cover. Germinates in 10–15 days
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 10–15 cm in March, pinch to 3 pairs of leaves for branching
Plant out / space	Mid-March, 20 cm apart. Sun, poor to average soil (rich soil makes leaves, not flowers)
Support	One layer of netting at 40 cm
Protect	Hardy to −5°C. Slug patrol
Pair with	Larkspur, nigella, cornflower
Keep away from	Over-fed ground
Back-up plan	A February sowing in the frame flowers in June–July for later use. Buy plugs in April as a rescue
Harvest: when	About 25 May to mid-July, when the lower 3–4 flowers on a stem are open
Harvest: how	Strip leaves, re-cut, cool water. Vase 5–7 days
Stems on 30 May	2–4 per plant. About 120 from 40 plants (range 30–200)

Orlaya grandiflora (suggest 40 plants)

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track. Hardy annual, carrot family. Not perennial
Sow / plant	29 Oct–15 Nov in modules, 5 mm deep. Germinates in 2–3 weeks. Seed is spiny and clings, so sow carefully
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 10 cm pinch the tip for branching
Plant out / space	Mid-March, 25 cm apart. Sun, free-draining
Support	One layer of netting at 40 cm
Protect	Hardy. Slug patrol. Mesh against pigeons
Pair with	Larkspur, sweet peas, cornflower
Keep away from	The carrot bed, as a precaution
Back-up plan	February sowing in the frame
Harvest: when	About 15 May to end of June, when half of the florets are open
Harvest: how	Cut long, strip lower leaves. Vase 5–7 days
Stems on 30 May	4–6 per plant. About 200 from 40 plants (range 100–320)

Nigella 'Persian Jewels' (suggest 40 plants)

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track. Hardy annual, buttercup family. Not perennial

Field	Plan
Sow / plant	29 Oct–15 Nov in deep root trainers (it hates root disturbance), 5 mm deep. Overflow: sow direct in the bed under mesh
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Optional at 10 cm for more branches
Plant out / space	Mid-March, 20 cm apart. Sun
Support	One layer of netting at 30 cm
Protect	Hardy. Slug patrol
Pair with	Everything: it attracts hoverflies. Plant near brassicas and sweet peas
Keep away from	Nothing specific
Back-up plan	Sow direct in March for June flowers and seed pods
Harvest: when	About 15 May to July, when the first flower opens. Seedpods last for weeks
Harvest: how	Cut long, re-cut, cool water. Vase 4–5 days for flowers, weeks for pods
Stems on 30 May	3 per plant. About 120 from 40 plants (range 60–200)

Cornflower (suggest 60 plants)

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ Worth including: autumn-sown plants flower from mid-May. Hardy annual. Not perennial
Sow / plant	29 Oct–15 Nov, 3 seeds per module cell, 5 mm deep. Germinates in 7–10 days
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Yes. At 15 cm (3 pairs of leaves) pinch the tip for 4–6 stems per plant
Plant out / space	Mid-March, 20–25 cm apart. Sun, poor soil is fine
Support	One layer of netting at 40–50 cm
Protect	Hardy to −10°C. Slug patrol. Mesh against pigeons while small
Pair with	Poppies, larkspur, nigella, orlaya
Keep away from	Nothing specific. Do not feed
Back-up plan	February sowing flowers in June, so not for the wedding but fine for later
Harvest: when	From about 15 May to July, when half of the flower is open
Harvest: how	Strip lower leaves, cool water. Vase 5–7 days
Stems on 30 May	3–6 per plant. About 240 from 60 plants (range 120–400)

Poppy 'Bridal Silk' (Papaver somniferum, suggest 30 plants)

Field	Plan
At a glance	⚠ Borderline: late May to June. Hardy annual. Not perennial
Sow / plant	29 Oct–15 Nov. Sow into deep root trainers in the frame (one tray in the ledger), mixing seed with fine sand. It resents root disturbance, so handle the roots gently when planting out
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	None
Plant out / space	Harden off 5–14 March, plant out 15–25 March into bed 1 at 20–25 cm. Sun
Support	Netting at 60 cm

Field	Plan
Protect	Mesh over the bed (mice eat the seed). Slug patrol
Pair with	Nigella, cornflower, larkspur
Keep away from	Fresh manure
Back-up plan	Sow more in modules in February. They flower in June, so they cover the days after 1 June but not 30 May
Harvest: when	When the bud begins to crack and shows colour, usually 25 May–30 Jun
Harvest: how	Sear: dip 2–3 cm of the stem end in just-boiled water for 5–10 seconds, then plunge into cold water. Vase 2–4 days
Stems on 30 May	About 1 per plant. About 30 from 30 plants (range 10–60)

Iceland poppies: 'Iceland Giant' and Colibri 'Dolce Vita'

Field	Plan
At a glance	🎲 Gamble for 30 May. Short-lived perennial, usually sown June–September to flower the following spring. Packets say April–June or May–July because that assumes the packet's sowing time; an end-October sowing gives small plants into winter, so flowering slips to June or later. Perennial (short-lived)
Sow / plant	Gamble: sow 29 Oct–15 Nov in modules, surface-sown with a vermiculite dusting, in the frame (in the ledger as part of the 1.5-tray gambles). Also sow on a windowsill in February if you want a second chance
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	None
Plant out / space	At 4–6 leaves, 15–31 March, 20 cm apart. Avoid root disturbance. Sun
Support	None for 'Dolce Vita' (dwarf). Netting for 'Iceland Giant'
Protect	Slug patrol. Mesh against pigeons
Pair with	Nigella, cornflower, poppies
Keep away from	Wet winter soil
Back-up plan	Sow again in June–July 2027 for flowers from spring 2028. If the frame fills in March, these gambles are the first to go (Part 3)
Harvest: when	Bud cracking, usually June onwards. Treat any 30 May flowers as a bonus
Harvest: how	Sear stem ends for 5–10 seconds in just-boiled water
Stems on 30 May	0–1 per plant. Do not count on them

Scabiosa 'Salmon Queen'

Field	Plan
At a glance	❌ Flowers from June (seed-to-flower about 90–110 days). Annual. Not perennial
Sow / plant	Gamble: sow now in the frame. Main sowing mid-Feb to March at 15–18°C on a windowsill, surface-sown
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 15–20 cm pinch above 4–6 pairs for more stems
Plant out / space	Mid-April after hardening off. 30 cm apart. Sun

Field	Plan
Support	One layer of netting at 60 cm
Protect	Slug patrol. Aphids
Pair with	Nigella, cornflower, marigold
Keep away from	Shade and wet clay
Back-up plan	Use the 31 May–1 Jun gap as a bonus: any flowers that open early go straight into the vase
Harvest: when	When 1–2 flowers are open: June–September
Harvest: how	Long stems, cool water. Vase 7–8 days
Stems on 30 May	Usually 0

Thlaspi arvensis (suggest 20 plants)

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track (check the packet for height). Hardy annual, brassica family. Not perennial
Sow / plant	29 Oct–15 Nov. Sow tiny seed in modules, barely covered, in the frame
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	None
Plant out / space	Mid-March, 20 cm apart. Sun to part shade
Support	Light netting if it flops
Protect	Flea beetle: fine mesh. Slug patrol
Pair with	Stocks and the cabbage-family block
Keep away from	Plots where brassicas grew recently
Back-up plan	Sow direct in March for later flowers
Harvest: when	April–June, when flowers or green seed discs have formed
Harvest: how	Cut long. Vase 7–10 days
Stems on 30 May	About 5 per plant. About 100 from 20 plants (range 60–150)

Didiscus caerulea 'Lacy Pink'

Field	Plan
At a glance	❌ Half-hardy annual, flowers June–July from a February sowing. Not perennial
Sow / plant	Late January to February at 15–18°C on a windowsill, in individual pots (it resents root disturbance)
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 4 leaves pinch the tip
Plant out / space	Late April after hardening off. 25 cm apart. Sun, sheltered
Support	One layer of netting at 40 cm
Protect	Fleece on frosty nights. Aphids
Pair with	Cornflower, nigella
Keep away from	Cold wet soil
Back-up plan	Buy plugs in April, or use more orlaya for the lacy look
Harvest: when	June–July. Any early heads are a bonus
Harvest: how	Pick when half the florets are open. Vase 5–7 days
Stems on 30 May	Usually 0

Eucalyptus pulverulenta ('Baby Blue', foliage)

Field	Plan
At a glance	⚠ Foliage only: usable if sown in February. Tender evergreen, grown as an annual. Perennial in theory (coastal gardens can overwinter)
Sow / plant	Mid-February in a propagator or on a warm windowsill at 15–20°C. Surface-sow, barely cover. Suggest 15 plants
Pot up	1–15 April: pot on into individual pots (it grows about 30 cm a week). Harden off 5–14 May, plant out 15–20 May
Pinch out	At 15–20 cm pinch to 3–4 pairs for bushy stems
Plant out / space	Mid-May after hardening off, 40 cm apart. Sun
Support	A cane per plant: it grows 30 cm a week
Protect	Fleece on frosty nights. Wind
Pair with	Lavender, geum
Keep away from	Small flowers that it will shade
Back-up plan	Buy 6 plants in April
Harvest: when	From 25 May as juvenile blue-grey foliage reaches 40–60 cm
Harvest: how	Cut stems, strip lower leaves, split woody ends, cool water. Lasts 2+ weeks
Stems on 30 May	3–6 per plant. About 90 from 15 plants (range 40–150) if the plants are established. They go out only 15–20 May, so cut lightly: plan on about 20 stems unless you buy larger plants

Achillea 'The Pearl'

Field	Plan
At a glance	❌ First-year seed-raised plants flower from July. Perennial
Sow / plant	February–March at 15–20°C, then prick out. Or buy a 1 L plant now
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 15 cm for bushier plants
Plant out / space	Mid-May, 40 cm apart. Sun
Support	Netting at 50 cm
Protect	Slug patrol. It spreads: edge the bed
Pair with	Geum, lavender, rosemary
Keep away from	Shade
Back-up plan	A bought 1 L plant may produce a few stems in late May. Otherwise use orlaya for white
Harvest: when	July–August in year one
Harvest: how	Cut when most florets are open. Vase 7–10 days
Stems on 30 May	0 from seed

Clary sage

Field	Plan
At a glance	❌ Salvia sclarea is biennial and flowers in its second year (2028). If your packet says Salvia viridis, it is a hardy annual. Check the packet

Field	Plan
Sow / plant	S. sclarea: sow in March for 2028. S. viridis: sow now in modules, plant out in March
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	S. viridis: at 15 cm for branching
Plant out / space	30 cm apart. Sun, dry soil
Support	Netting at 40 cm for S. viridis
Protect	Slug patrol
Pair with	Lavender, rosemary. Sage beside cabbages
Keep away from	Wet clay
Back-up plan	Use sage and mint foliage as the green filler
Harvest: when	S. viridis: June. S. sclarea: June–July 2028
Harvest: how	Cut when bracts are coloured. Vase 5–7 days
Stems on 30 May	0–1

Lemon bergamot (Monarda citriodora)

Field	Plan
At a glance	⚠ Foliage only by 30 May. Annual or short-lived perennial
Sow / plant	Mid-Feb to March at 15–18°C, surface-sown
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 15 cm to make bushy
Plant out / space	Mid-May, 30 cm apart. Sun
Support	Netting
Protect	Mildew in dry soil: water well
Pair with	Herbs, geum
Keep away from	Dry, shaded soil
Back-up plan	Use mint and applemint for scent
Harvest: when	Foliage from late May. Flowers July–September
Harvest: how	Cut 20–30 cm stems, strip lower leaves. Scented
Stems on 30 May	About 5 foliage stems per plant

Lunaria 'Fine Mixed' (honesty)

Field	Plan
At a glance	❌ Biennial, brassica family. Flowers spring of the year after sowing
Sow / plant	Sow outdoors June–July 2027 for flowers and silver discs in 2028
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	None
Plant out / space	Transplant 15 Sep–31 Oct 2027 into the brassica-family bed (bed 2 moves to bed 1's ground in 2028), 30 cm apart. Part shade
Support	None

Field	Plan
Protect	Flea beetle: mesh
Pair with	The cabbage-family block
Keep away from	Plots where cabbages grew
Back-up plan	Optional gamble, not in the cold-frame ledger: if a spare pot is free, sow a few seeds now under mesh. It may flower late in 2027 but is more likely in 2028. The frame has no room for a tray
Harvest: when	2028
Harvest: how	Flowers when open, discs when dried
Stems on 30 May	0

Geum 'Cosmopolitan' ×5 (1 L pots)

Field	Plan
At a glance	✅ On track. Perennial, flowers late May–July
Sow / plant	Plant 29 Oct to mid-November (or March) in bed 4, the perennial bed. Dig in compost, plant at pot depth, water in, mulch
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	None
Plant out / space	Final position in bed 4, 40 cm apart (five plants take about 0.8 m² of its 2.5 m²). Sun to part shade
Support	None
Protect	Slug patrol. Check roots for vine weevil grubs. Mulch in winter
Pair with	Lavender, achillea, allium
Keep away from	Strawberries (both attract vine weevil; bed 4 is at the far north end, bed 3 well south of it)
Back-up plan	If flowers are late, cut stems with buds and open them in warm water
Harvest: when	From about 20 May, when the first flowers open on a stem
Harvest: how	Cut thin stems early, plain water. Vase 5–7 days
Stems on 30 May	6–10 per plant in year one. About 40 from 5 plants (range 25–60)

"Phenomena … the brick" (unidentified)

I could not identify this plant from the handwriting. Tell me its name and I will add a full card.

B. Other flowers (not for the wedding)

Daffodils (variety and number not stated)

Field	Plan
At a glance	Bulb. Perennial. Spring colour and rodent barrier around planters T and R
Sow / plant	Now to mid-November, 15 cm deep (3× bulb height), pointed end up
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Not applicable

Field	Plan
Plant out / space	Final position. 10–15 cm apart, ringing planters T and R in the ground. Sun to part shade
Support	None
Protect	Toxic to rodents, so they protect others. Leave foliage for 6 weeks after flowering
Pair with	Tulips, alliums, geum
Keep away from	Cut daffodils mixed in a vase with other flowers (sap harms them)
Back-up plan	Plant until the ground freezes: late planting still flowers
Harvest: when	March–April, at gooseneck stage
Harvest: how	Stand alone in water for 12–24 hours before mixing
Yield	1 stem per bulb, returning every year

Dahlias ×7 (tubers)

Field	Plan
At a glance	Tender perennial. Flowers August–October
Sow / plant	Pot up in late March–early April in 3 L pots of compost, frost-free (frame with fleece or a windowsill)
Pot up	25 March–10 April: tubers into 3 L pots of compost, frost-free
Pinch out	At 30 cm with 3–4 pairs of leaves, pinch above the third pair for 6+ stems per plant
Plant out / space	After the last frost, 15–25 May, 60–75 cm apart in bed 7 (in the ground, not in a planter). Sun, rich soil. Pot up the tubers into 3 L pots 25 Mar–10 Apr and harden off 1–14 May
Support	A 1.2 m stake per plant, put in at planting
Protect	Slugs are the main threat: nematodes from March, collars or wool pellets. Earwigs: upturned pot of straw on a cane
Pair with	Marigold (slug decoy), cosmos, basil
Keep away from	Wind and wet clay
Back-up plan	Take basal cuttings in April. Buy 3 plants in May as insurance
Harvest: when	August–October. Pick when the flower is fully open (dahlias do not open further after cutting)
Harvest: how	Cut long in the evening, strip leaves, condition overnight. Optional: sear stem ends 10 seconds in hot water
Yield	15–25 stems per plant, about 100–175 from 7. In mild coastal soil mulch 10–15 cm in November, or lift and store dry

Candytuft 'Spangles'

Field	Plan
At a glance	Hardy annual, brassica family. Not perennial
Sow / plant	March–May direct, 5 mm deep, or in modules
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 10 cm if sown in modules
Plant out / space	Thin or plant out to 15 cm. Sun
Support	None
Protect	Flea beetle: fine mesh. Clubroot: brassica block
Pair with	Marigold, nigella
Keep away from	Soil that recently grew brassicas

Field	Plan
Back-up plan	Sow again in May
Harvest: when	June–August, half open
Harvest: how	Cut long, cool water. Vase 5–7 days
Yield	5–8 stems per plant

Marigold 'Fireball'

Field	Plan
At a glance	Annual. Not perennial. Check the packet: French marigold (Tagetes) or pot marigold (Calendula)
Sow / plant	Sow in March–April on a windowsill, or direct in May
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 15 cm pinch the tip
Plant out / space	After frost, late May, 25–30 cm apart. Sun
Support	None
Protect	Slug patrol
Pair with	Tomatoes, peppers, dahlias, brassicas (hoverflies and whitefly deterrent)
Keep away from	Nothing specific
Back-up plan	Sow again in May
Harvest: when	July–October
Harvest: how	Cut long. Deadhead to keep it flowering
Yield	10–20 flowers per plant

Rudbeckia (variety not stated)

Field	Plan
At a glance	Annual or short-lived perennial: depends on the species. Daisy family
Sow / plant	February–March at 18°C on a windowsill, surface-sown
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	At 15 cm pinch above 3 pairs
Plant out / space	Mid-May, 40 cm apart. Sun
Support	Netting at 60 cm
Protect	Slug patrol
Pair with	Dahlias, statice, helichrysum
Keep away from	Shade
Back-up plan	Sow direct in May
Harvest: when	July–October
Harvest: how	Cut when fully open. Vase 7–10 days
Yield	8–15 stems per plant

Statice 'Pink Pokers' and Helichrysum 'Kingsize Mixed' and 'Silvery Rose' (for drying)

Field	Plan
At a glance	Half-hardy annuals. Not perennial

Field	Plan
Sow / plant	Statice: February–March at 18°C. Helichrysum: March–April at 18°C. Surface-sow both
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Helichrysum: at 15 cm for branching
Plant out / space	Late May after frost, 30 cm apart. Sun
Support	Netting at 50 cm for tall helichrysum
Protect	Slug patrol. Aphids
Pair with	Rudbeckia, dahlias
Keep away from	Wet soil
Back-up plan	Sow again in April
Harvest: when	Statice: July–September when flowers colour. Helichrysum: when 1–2 rows of petals have opened
Harvest: how	Strip leaves, hang upside down in bunches in a dark, airy spot for 2–3 weeks
Yield	10–20 stems per plant

C. Vegetables and fruit

Beetroot 'Detroit 2'

Field	Plan
At a glance	Biennial, grown as annual. Not perennial
Sow / plant	Direct from 25 March, 2 cm deep, rows 30 cm apart. Sow 3 m of row every 3 weeks to mid-July
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Not applicable. Thin to 10 cm after 3 weeks (thinnings are edible)
Plant out / space	10 cm apart in rows 30 cm apart
Support	None
Protect	Fleece on early sowings. Slug patrol. Pigeons: net
Pair with	Onions, brassicas, lettuce
Keep away from	Runner beans
Back-up plan	Succession sowings spread the risk
Harvest: when	From mid-June, at golf-ball to tennis-ball size. Use by late October
Harvest: how	Twist off the leaves (never cut, it bleeds). Lift with a fork
Yield	About 20 beets per metre of row

Onion 'Red Herald' F1

Field	Plan
At a glance	Biennial, grown as annual. Onion family. Not perennial
Sow / plant	Mid-January to mid-February, 4–5 seeds per module cell, at 10–15°C (windowsill, not the frame)
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Do not thin: grow as clumps
Plant out / space	Early to mid April, 25 cm apart in clumps. Sun, firm soil
Support	None
Protect	Fleece or fine mesh in spring against onion fly and allium leaf miner

Field	Plan
Pair with	Carrots, beetroot, lettuce, strawberries
Keep away from	Peas and beans. Soil with white rot
Back-up plan	Buy onion sets in March
Harvest: when	August–September, when tops fall
Harvest: how	Lift, dry in sun or a greenhouse for 2 weeks, store in net bags
Yield	About 6–8 onions per clump of 5

Cabbages: 'Primo II' (green) and 'Red Kalibo' (pointed red)

Field	Plan
At a glance	Biennial, grown as annual. Brassica family. Not perennial
Sow / plant	Primo II: 1–15 March in modules in the frame (germinates in 7–21 days). Red Kalibo: early April in modules in the frame
Pot up	Red Kalibo only, optional, 10–20 May: pot on if the modules are root-bound. Primo II goes straight from module to bed 2
Pinch out	Not applicable
Plant out / space	Primo II: late April–May. Red Kalibo: 1–15 June, after planter T clears (8 plants, with marigolds). Both 45 cm apart each way. Plant firmly
Support	None
Protect	Insect mesh on hoops from planting. Root-fly collars. Lime if soil is below pH 6.5 (clubroot). Pigeons: net
Pair with	Onions, thyme, sage, rosemary, mint in pots, marigold
Keep away from	Strawberries, tomatoes, runner beans. Any soil that grew brassicas recently
Back-up plan	Sow a second lot in April. Buy plugs if a batch fails
Harvest: when	Primo II: July–October. Red Kalibo: September–November
Harvest: how	Cut the head with a sharp knife, leaving the stump so side-sprouts form
Yield	12 Primo II in bed 2, 8 Red Kalibo in planter T. One head per plant, 1–1.5 kg each

Carrots: 'Harlequin' F1 and plain carrots

Field	Plan
At a glance	Biennial, grown as annual. Carrot family. Not perennial
Sow / plant	Direct from 20 March, 1 cm deep, rows 20–25 cm apart. Sow thinly every 3–4 weeks to mid-July (July sowings go in planter R, under insect mesh)
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Not applicable. Thin to 5–7 cm in the evening on damp days
Plant out / space	5–7 cm apart. Stone-free, unmanured soil
Support	None
Protect	Mesh barrier 80 cm high. Never thin in daylight: the smell draws carrot fly
Pair with	Onions, chives, rosemary, lettuce
Keep away from	Dill, parsnip, parsley
Back-up plan	Succession sowing

Field	Plan
Harvest: when	July–November
Harvest: how	Loosen the soil with a fork and lift. Twist off the leaves
Yield	About 1 kg per metre of row

Tomatoes: 'Buffalosteak' (beefsteak cordon) and 'Toddler' (dwarf bush)

Field	Plan
At a glance	Tender perennial, grown as annual. Not perennial here
Sow / plant	10–25 March at 18–21°C on a warm windowsill or propagator, then pot on
Pot up	10–25 April: pot on individually when the first true leaves show
Pinch out	Buffalosteak: nip out side-shoots weekly. Stop at 5–6 trusses in early August. Toddler: do not pinch
Plant out / space	Late May to early June, after hardening off. Buffalosteak 50 cm apart, Toddler 45 cm apart
Support	Buffalosteak: 1.8 m cane or string. Toddler: short stake
Protect	Fleece or cloche until June. Blight: strip lower leaves, space well, water at the base
Pair with	Basil, marigold, chives
Keep away from	Brassicas, fennel, potatoes
Back-up plan	Buy plants in May
Harvest: when	Toddler: July–September. Buffalosteak: August–October
Harvest: how	Pick when fully coloured. Feed weekly with tomato feed after the first truss sets
Yield	Buffalosteak: 2–4 kg per plant. Toddler: 1–2 kg

Peppers: sweet hybrid and 'Snackbite' mixed

Field	Plan
At a glance	Tender perennial, grown as annual. Not perennial here
Sow / plant	15 February–5 March at 20–25°C in a propagator (7–21 days to germinate)
Pot up	1–20 April: pot on individually
Pinch out	At 20–25 cm pinch the tip for bushy plants
Plant out / space	Early to mid June, 45 cm apart, in the warmest spot or under a cloche
Support	A cane per plant
Protect	Fleece on cold nights. Aphids. Birds
Pair with	Basil, onions, carrots, marigold
Keep away from	Fennel, brassicas
Back-up plan	Buy plants in May
Harvest: when	August–October
Harvest: how	Cut with scissors, leaving a short stalk. Feed weekly
Yield	8–15 fruit per plant

Strawberry 'Fenella'

Field	Plan
At a glance	Perennial. Mid-season fruit. Replace plants every 3–4 years

Field	Plan
Sow / plant	Arrives March: plant at once with the crown level with the soil. If frozen, hold in the frame. Suggest 20 plants
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Remove flowers in the first spring if plants are bare-root. Cut runners unless you want new plants
Plant out / space	40 cm apart in rows 75 cm apart
Support	Straw mulch under the fruit in May
Protect	Net the bed. Slug patrol. Mice and birds take ripe fruit: pick daily
Pair with	Borage, chives, thyme, lettuce, marigold
Keep away from	Brassicas, tomatoes, fennel
Back-up plan	Peg down 10 runners in a pot each July as spares
Harvest: when	June–July (small crop in 2027, full crop in 2028)
Harvest: how	Pick when fully red with the stalk. Eat or chill the same day
Yield	About 300–500 g per plant in a full year

D. Herbs

Basil

Field	Plan
At a glance	Tender annual. Not perennial
Sow / plant	20 April–10 May on a warm windowsill (18–21°C), sprinkle seed and barely cover
Pot up	15 May–5 June: prick out into small pots, harden off 5–14 June
Pinch out	At 3–4 pairs of leaves pinch above a pair, and keep pinching flower buds
Plant out / space	Mid-June, 25 cm apart, in the tomato bed
Support	None
Protect	Cold nights below 10°C: wait until mid-June. Slug patrol
Pair with	Tomatoes, peppers
Keep away from	Cold, wet corners
Back-up plan	Sow again in June
Harvest: when	July–September
Harvest: how	Pinch off the top 2 pairs of leaves, never strip stems bare
Yield	About 20 pickings per plant

Chives

Field	Plan
At a glance	Hardy perennial, onion family
Sow / plant	March–April in modules at 15–18°C, 5–6 seeds per cell
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Not applicable
Plant out / space	May, clumps 20 cm apart. Sun to part shade
Support	None

Field	Plan
Protect	Fleece or fine mesh against allium leaf miner in March–April and October–November
Pair with	Carrots, strawberries, tomatoes
Keep away from	Peas and beans
Back-up plan	Divide a neighbour's clump
Harvest: when	From May, all season
Harvest: how	Cut to 5 cm above the soil. Cut back hard after flowering
Yield	Keeps coming. Divide every 3 years

Thyme

Field	Plan
At a glance	Evergreen perennial
Sow / plant	March–April, surface-sown at 15–18°C. Germination takes 2–3 weeks. Or buy a plant
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Pinch tips in the first year for a bushy plant
Plant out / space	May, 25 cm apart. Full sun, sharp drainage
Support	None
Protect	Wet winters: add grit
Pair with	Cabbages, strawberries, carrots
Keep away from	Wet clay
Back-up plan	Buy a pot plant in April
Harvest: when	From June, all year
Harvest: how	Snip tips. Trim lightly after flowering, never into old wood
Yield	Keeps coming

Mint and applemint

Field	Plan
At a glance	Hardy perennial, invasive
Sow / plant	March–April. Plants or divisions are easier than seed. Mint (Mentha spicata) has pointed, toothed leaves and a sharp scent. Applemint has rounder, softer, hairier leaves and a milder fruity scent. Grow each in its own sunk pot in bed 9, well apart, because they hybridise
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Pinch tips to branch
Plant out / space	Always in a bucket or large pot sunk into the soil (bed 9, or beside the brassica block), 30 cm apart. Part shade, moist
Support	None
Protect	Mint rust: bin affected leaves. Cut back in autumn
Pair with	Cabbages, tomatoes
Keep away from	Direct planting in beds. Planting next to each other (they hybridise)
Back-up plan	A cutting in a glass of water roots in 2 weeks

Field	Plan
Harvest: when	May–October
Harvest: how	Cut stems, strip leaves as needed. For your wedding use whichever has more leaf as scented green (applemint is softer and prettier in arrangements)
Yield	Keeps coming

Rosemary

Field	Plan
At a glance	Evergreen perennial shrub
Sow / plant	Buy a plant in April. Seed is slow and unreliable: sow in March at 18–21°C if you want to try
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Pinch tips in year one
Plant out / space	May, 60–90 cm apart. Full sun, sharp drainage
Support	None
Protect	Fleece in hard frost the first winter
Pair with	Carrots, cabbages, sage
Keep away from	Wet clay, mint
Back-up plan	Take 10 cm cuttings in July
Harvest: when	All year
Harvest: how	Snip tips. Prune lightly after flowering
Yield	Keeps coming

Lavender (variety not stated, faint on the list)

Field	Plan
At a glance	Evergreen perennial shrub. First flowers in year two
Sow / plant	February–March at 15–20°C, surface-sown. Germination takes 2–4 weeks
Pot up	Not applicable (direct sown, or module or bought plant straight to its final place)
Pinch out	Pinch tips in year one
Plant out / space	May–June, 45 cm apart. Full sun, very free-draining
Support	None
Protect	Wet winters: add grit
Pair with	Rosemary, thyme, geum
Keep away from	Wet clay
Back-up plan	Buy plugs in April
Harvest: when	July–August in year two, as buds colour
Harvest: how	Cut long stems in bud, hang to dry. Cut back by a third after flowering
Yield	20–30 stems per plant in year two

Part 8. Month-by-month checklist

Start with the week-one table, then tick these off through the year. The shopping list is at the end. Dates assume mild southern England. Move any date 1–2 weeks to suit the weather. They match the calendar tables in Part 3, where each plant's sow, pot up, harden off, plant out and harvest dates are listed separately.

Week one: 29 October to 15 November

Only what must happen in this window. Everything else waits.

By	Job	Notes
29–31 Oct	Line the cold-frame floor with 6 mm mesh, close every gap	Do this before any seed goes in
29 Oct–10 Nov	**Sow all 74 sweet peas** into root trainers, mesh over the trays	Soak overnight first. 48 go on the plot, 26 to your garden. 'Spring Sunshine' sow the same week
29 Oct–5 Nov	Sow stocks batch 1 (3 varieties)	
29 Oct–15 Nov	Sow larkspur, clarkia, orlaya, nigella, cornflower, Thlaspi, Bridal Silk poppy	Frame, under mesh. Check the tray ledger: about 14 of 18 trays by 5 Nov
29 Oct–15 Nov	Sow the gambles: Iceland poppies, scabiosa, clary sage (only if Salvia viridis)	These are the first to go if the frame fills
29 Oct	Store tulip batch 2 in a lidded metal tin at 5–9 °C	Check weekly for mould
29 Oct–8 Nov	**Buy and build planter T** (mesh base, mesh up the sides)	Needed before the tulips
1–8 Nov	Pot up ranunculus batch 1 (about 40 corms) into trays, 3 cm deep	Soak 3–4 hours only
By 20 Nov (aim for 8 Nov)	**Plant tulip batch 1** (about 48 bulbs) in planter T, 10–15 cm deep. Mesh lid straight away	The rest of T is left for batch 2 in January
29 Oct–15 Nov	Plant your 10 alliums in T between the tulips, and the daffodil ring on the ground round where T and R will stand (leave room for the planter)	10–15 cm deep
29 Oct–15 Nov	Plant Geum x5 in bed 4	Compost, plant at pot depth, mulch
From 29 Oct	Fleece or fine mesh over alliums and chives	Leaf miner flies in Oct and Nov
29 Oct–15 Nov	Set 6 snap traps in tunnels. Start the weekly 5-minute patrol	
Late Nov	First frost: lid on the frame and fleece over the trays	Have the fleece ready before the end of week one

October (from the 29th)

☐ Buy planter T (180 × 90 cm, 25 cm deep). Lay the 6 mm mesh base, set the planter on it and fold the mesh up the sides (Part 4, Part 5)
☐ Plant tulip batch 1 (about 48 bulbs) in planter T, 10–15 cm deep, by 20 November. Lay a mesh lid over at once
☐ Plant the daffodil ring round T and R, and the alliums (by 15 November)

☐ Sow all 74 sweet peas ('Muse', 'Fire & Ice', 'High Scent', 'Spring Sunshine') into root trainers in the frame, under mesh (by 10 November). 48 go on the plot (24 per planter), 26 to your garden
☐ Sow stocks batch 1 (by 5 November)
☐ Sow larkspur, clarkia, orlaya, nigella, cornflower, Thlaspi and Bridal Silk poppy in trays or root trainers in the frame (by 15 November)
☐ Sow the gambles in the frame: Iceland poppies, scabiosa, clary sage (only if it is Salvia viridis)
☐ Put fleece or fine mesh over alliums and chives (leaf miner window, Oct–Nov)
☐ Store tulip batch 2 in a lidded tin at 5–9°C
☐ Buy snap traps, mesh, fleece, insect mesh, hoops. Order slug nematodes for March

November

☐ 1–8 November: pot up ranunculus batch 1 (corms into trays, 3 cm deep), in the frame
☐ Finish all bulb and seed sowing by 15 November
☐ Plant Geum ×5 in bed 4 by 15 November
☐ Line the cold-frame base with 6 mm mesh and close every gap
☐ Start the weekly rodent patrol
☐ Fleece and frame lid on from the first frost (late November)

December

☐ Pinch sweet peas at 2–3 pairs of leaves
☐ Vent the frame on mild days. Fleece in frosts
☐ Check stored tulip bulbs for mould and gnawing
☐ Check every mesh for gaps. Reset traps
☐ Order seed and plugs you still need

January 2027

☐ **3–10 January: plant tulip batch 2** in the other half of planter T. Mesh lid over
☐ 15 January onwards: sow onions indoors (15 January–15 February)
☐ 25 January–15 February: sow Didiscus on a windowsill
☐ Pinch any remaining sweet peas
☐ Check the strawberry delivery date

February

☐ 10–25 February: sow eucalyptus. 15 February–15 March: sow lemon bergamot, scabiosa (main sowing), rudbeckia, statice and lavender at 15–20°C
☐ 15 February–5 March: sow peppers (propagator at 20–25°C)
☐ 15–28 February: sow stocks batch 2 (back-up)
☐ **20–28 February: pot up ranunculus batch 2** (soak the corms 3–4 hours only)
☐ Mid-February: buy planter R
☐ Order nematodes if you have not

March

☐ 1–15 March: sow cabbage 'Primo II'. 1 March–15 April: sow chives and thyme. 10–25 March: sow tomatoes

☐ 5–14 March: harden off the autumn-sown annuals and ranunculus batch 1
☐ 15–25 March: plant out the autumn-sown hardy annuals, stocks batch 1 and Bridal Silk poppy (hardened off) into bed 1 and bed 2. Plant out ranunculus batch 1 into planter R and the Iceland poppies and clary sage (by 31 March)
☐ From 20 March: sow carrots and beetroot direct. Repeat every 3–4 weeks
☐ 15 March–15 April: sow marigold and helichrysum. 15 March onwards: sow candytuft direct
☐ 15–24 March: harden off sweet peas. Mid-March: buy planters S1 and S2
☐ 25 March–5 April: plant out sweet peas, one plant per cane every 15 cm: 24 Spring Sunshine into S1 and 24 of the others into S2 (24 canes in each). The other 26 go to your garden
☐ Strawberries arrive: plant at once (by 31 March), net the bed
☐ Apply slug nematodes once soil is above 5°C
☐ 25 March–10 April: pot up dahlias tubers into 3 L pots
☐ Put netting up for supported flowers (larkspur, stocks, cornflower)
☐ Fleece alliums and chives again (leaf miner, Mar–Apr). Plant mint and applemint in sunk pots

April

☐ 1–10 April: plant out ranunculus batch 2 (harden off from 25 March). Sow Red Kalibo. Plant out onion clumps (5–15 April)
☐ 1–20 April: pot up peppers. 10–25 April: pot up tomatoes. 1–15 April: pot up eucalyptus
☐ 12–20 April: plant out stocks batch 2. Mid-April: average last frost
☐ 15 April onwards: plant out achillea, rosemary, chives and thyme (buy plants). Plant out scabiosa (15–25 April) and Didiscus (23–30 April)
☐ 25 April: start planting out 'Primo II' (to 15 May)
☐ Fleece on tender plants for frosty nights until May
☐ Pinch cornflower, clarkia and orlaya
☐ 20 April: sow basil indoors (to 10 May)
☐ Put insect mesh on hoops over cabbages and carrots

May

☐ Plant out eucalyptus (15–20 May). Plant out lemon bergamot and rudbeckia (10–20 May)
☐ 10 May: first sweet pea picks
☐ **9–16 May: pull tulip batch 1.** Wrap in newspaper, fridge
☐ 15–25 May: plant out dahlias. 25 May–10 June: plant out tomatoes. 20–31 May: plant out marigold, statice and helichrysum, once frost-free

20–23 May: pull tulip batch 2

☐ Clear the fridge of fruit. Clean buckets and cutters
☐ Shade cloth ready if it turns hot
☐ **29 May evening:** take out tulips, re-cut and stand in cold water
☐ **30 May: harvest day.** Cut, sear poppies, condition in a cool dark place
☐ 31 May: sort and arrange. **1 June: wedding**

June

☐ Clear planters T and R once the flowers finish. Plant 8 Red Kalibo in T with marigolds (1–15 June). Sow late carrots and beetroot in R under insect mesh

☐ 5–15 June: plant out peppers. 15–25 June: plant out basil
☐ Strawberry harvest begins. Net, pick daily
☐ Cut back lavender and thyme after flowering
☐ 1 June–15 July: sow Lunaria and Iceland poppies for 2028

July–August

☐ Harvest beetroot, carrots, cabbage, onions, tomatoes
☐ Cut and hang statice and helichrysum to dry
☐ Last carrot sowing by mid-July. Take dahlia and rosemary cuttings
☐ Pull the sweet peas in late July. Sow a green manure or winter salads in S1 and S2
☐ Order bulbs for next spring

September–October 2027

☐ Lift and dry onions
☐ Cut dahlias until the first frost, then mulch 10–15 cm (or lift and store)
☐ Pick Red Kalibo. Clear beds, rotate families (Part 4)
☐ Transplant Lunaria (15 September–31 October)
☐ Plant next year's bulbs by late October

Shopping list

Priority: **Now** (week one), **Feb** (ranunculus planter), **Mar** (sweet pea planters and spring), **Later**. Items marked *optional* can be skipped or borrowed to save money.

Planters and soil

Item	Qty	When	Notes
Raised planters, 180 × 90 cm, 25 cm deep, no base	4 (2 minimum)	T now, R Feb, S1 and S2 Mar	No extenders
Galvanised welded mesh, 6 mm (1/4 inch)	About 20 m² (a 1 m x 20 m roll)	6 m² now (T base 3 m², T lid 2.5 m²); the rest later	Bases 4 × 3 m², lids for T and R 2 × 2.5 m², cold-frame floor and vents 1 m², tray covers 2 m² (offcuts)
Galvanised garden wire or heavy-duty cable ties	1 small roll	Now	Joining mesh, overlap 10 cm
Topsoil from the plot	About 0.2 m³ per planter	Now (T)	Dig from the plot
Compost (bulk bags or 100 L bags)	About 0.13 m³ per planter, so about 0.5 m³ for four	T now	Plus compost for pots and trays, below
Horticultural grit	About 0.07 m³ per planter, so about 8 bags of 25 L for four	T now (2 bags)	For drainage

Protection

Item	Spec and qty	When	Notes
Ground pegs or staples	About 150, galvanised, 15 cm	Now	Mesh lids every 20 cm, fleece and mesh edges

Item	Spec and qty	When	Notes
Fleece, heavy	30 gsm, 2 m x 10 m, 1 roll	Now	Frost: frame trays, ranunculus, tender plants (about 3–4 °C of protection)
Fleece, light	17 gsm, 2 m x 10 m, 1 roll	Now	Alliums and chives in the leaf-miner windows. *Optional if you use the insect mesh below for this*
Insect mesh	0.8 mm holes (stops flea beetle, cabbage fly, carrot fly, leaf miner), 2 m x 15 m	March	Covers bed 2 (brassicas), bed 6 (carrots), bed 5 (onions); 1.3 mm would do for carrot fly and cabbage white only
Hoops	About 26, 50–60 cm tall, to span 1.3 m beds	March	20 for beds 2, 5, 6; 6 for fleece over T and R
Snap traps with tunnels (or planks and pipe)	6	Now	Peanut butter bait. Birds and hedgehogs must not reach them
Slug nematodes	1 pack covering 40 m²	Order Feb, apply March	Beds 1, 2, 3, 7 and the planters total about 39 m²
Root-fly collars	20	April	For the 12 Primo II and 8 Red Kalibo. *Optional (cut from carpet underlay)*
Bird netting and a frame for strawberries	About 2 m x 5 m, canes	May	Bed 3 (1.3 × 4.1 m)
Cloche or shade cloth	1	May	Shade cloth only if it turns hot around 30 May. *Optional*

Sowing and growing

Item	Qty	When	Notes
Root trainers	About 144 cells (about 4–5 trays of 32)	Now	74 sweet peas (48 for the plot, 26 for your garden), 40 nigella, 30 Bridal Silk poppy
Module or cell trays (24-cell) and plug trays	Enough for the rest of the ledger, about 8 trays	Now	Your cold frame holds 18 tray-equivalents
Multi-purpose compost, seed compost and gritty mix for ranunculus	About 150 L in total, plus 20 L for ranunculus	Now	Estimate. Dahlia 3 L pots need about 21 L more in March
Vermiculite	1 small bag	Now	Dusting over Iceland poppy seed
Fine sand	1 small bag	Now	Mixed with Bridal Silk poppy seed
Canes, 2.4 m	48 (12 per row, 4 rows)	March	Sweet peas in S1 and S2 (one plant per cane). Spares for the dahlias are separate (7 stakes, 1.2 m)
Twine, or pea and bean netting	About 8 m of netting, or one ball of twine	March	
Lidded metal tin	1	Now	Tulip batch 2. *You may already own one*
Wood chip (free from tree surgeons or the site) and cardboard	About 3 m³	Spring	Paths are roughly 35 m². *Optional, do it gradually*

Sources and confidence

Most timings above are standard UK practice from general horticultural knowledge, so treat dates as ±2 weeks. Variety specifics were checked against supplier pages found in search: Sarah Raven for Shells on the Beach tulips, Eden Brothers for Tulip 'Beachberry', King's Seeds for Cabbage Primo II, and Plants of Distinction for Scabiosa 'Salmon Queen'. Stem counts are estimates for first-year plants.

Appendix A. Change log of the 29 October revisions

> **Status: merged into Parts 1 to 5, 7 and 8 on 29 October 2026.** This chapter is now a change log. The detailed text lives in the Parts. The shopping list and week-one page were approved and merged into Part 8 on 30 October 2026.

10.1 What changed since 27 October, and where it now lives

Sweet peas are 74, not 40 (40 plus 34 'Spring Sunshine', assumed seed). Part 1 (assumptions), Part 2, Part 7 (two sweet pea cards), Part 4 (planters S1 and S2).
The cold frame holds about 18 trays, not 8. Part 1, Part 3 (tray ledger, overflow rule removed).
Poppies: 'Bridal Silk' stays borderline. Iceland poppies and Colibri 'Dolce Vita' moved from "will not flower" to "gamble" (0 to 1 stem per plant on 30 May). Part 2, Part 7. Why the packets say April to June: a packet's window assumes the sowing time it recommends. Iceland poppies are normally sown in early autumn or spring; an end-October sowing gives small plants into winter, so flowering slips to June or later. Plants of Distinction lists Colibri 'Dolce Vita' as sow Feb to Sep with a May to July harvest; Vital Seeds gives June to August for its Iceland poppy guide.
The calendar separates five jobs (sow, pot up, harden off, plant out, harvest). Part 3 (chart and tables), Part 8 (monthly lists), Part 7 (new "Pot up" row on every card).
Raised planters: 4 in total (2 minimum), 1 needed now, no extenders. Planter depth is 25 cm (owner stated). Part 4 (Raised planters), Part 5 (mesh base and lid).
Plot layout to scale on 8 m x 15.6 m, north at the top, with a perimeter for each bed. Part 4. It replaces the zone budget.
Fleece how-to, 'undersow' definition, guard-plant table. Part 5 (fleece), Part 4 (undersow note, guard plants).
Spring Sunshine sweet peas. Part 7 card. One supplier page lists "very early flowering" and April to June (a mix sown September to October under cover); the UK supplier gives no flowering date. Confirm against the packet.

10.2 Findings from the merge

Sweet pea capacity: 4 rows x 10 canes x 2 plants is 80 (12 canes a row is the limit, 96). 74 fit. Earlier text said "capacity 96 with 10 canes a row"; corrected in Part 7.
Planter T is full: 105 tulips (about 8 × 10 cm) plus 10 alliums. Bed 1 is at capacity at 20 cm spacing (about 240 annuals plus 15 eucalyptus in 12.5 m²).
Tulips go 10 to 15 cm deep in the 25 cm planters (15 to 20 cm in open ground); ranunculus 3 cm; sweet peas are fine in 25 cm. Dahlias go in bed 7, not a planter.

10.7 Sources for these revisions

Sweet Pea Spring Sunshine, Plants of Distinction
Papaver Colibri Dolce Vita, Plants of Distinction
How To Grow Iceland Poppies, Vital Seeds

10.3 Update of 30 October 2026

Sweet peas: all 74 are still sown, but only 48 go on the plot (24 Spring Sunshine in S1, 24 of the others in S2, one plant per cane every 15 cm). The other 26 go in the owner's garden. A proposal to move

them to bed 7 was rejected (shade over neighbouring beds).
Stem forecast updated: sweet peas 192 card / 120 cautious (48 plants); flowers total about 1,570 / 880. Canes: 48.

Appendix B. Open items (TODO)

Status at 30 Oct 2026 (all build-out work done; two items need the owner, below): revisions merged into Parts 1 to 5, 7 and 8 (chapter 10 is now a change log). Shopping list and week-one page are drafts in `content/10-revisions-2026-10-29-shopping-and-week-one.md`, awaiting approval. `source/revised-plan-2026-10-29.html` and the media drawings are drafts and have not been regenerated.

Do first (time-sensitive, the plot is being sown now)

☑ Re-read the Part 8 checklist against the revised calendar and update dates that changed (see below).

Merge the 10-revisions chapter into the Parts (then trim chapter 10)

☑ Part 1: update findings 2, 3, 7 and the assumptions (cold frame 18 trays, sweet peas 74, poppies now “gamble”).
☑ Part 2: change Iceland poppies and Colibri ‘Dolce Vita’ from red cross to gamble; add Spring Sunshine sweet peas row; sweet peas count to 74.
☑ Part 3: replace the single-bar Gantt image with the by-job calendar (`media/gantt-revised.png`); rebuild the cold-frame ledger for 18 trays; remove the overflow rule. Part 3’s intro promises a wedding countdown, a stem forecast and a plot zone budget chart that the original PDF never contained: create them or remove the promise.
☑ Part 4: replace the zone budget with the scaled layout (`media/plot-layout.svg`), the planter plan and guard-plant table; update rotation notes for the new bed numbers; include perimeter measurements for each bed.
☑ Part 5: update mesh guidance for planters (6 mm base and sides, mesh lid), and the fleece how-to;
☑ Part 7: sweet pea card (74 plants, planters S1 and S2, canes); poppy cards (Iceland gamble, sow dates); add a Spring Sunshine card; add pot-up rows where the calendar has them; update Zone letters to bed numbers.
☑ Part 8: month lists updated to the revised calendar (jobs now separate; poppies, sweet peas, cold frame changes).

Gaps and checks

☑ Verify the Spring Sunshine flowering time and daylength behaviour from a supplier page or the packet.
☑ Add cards for items on the Bible’s contents list that lack one or are thin: Lunaria gamble, Geum planting, applemint vs mint.
☑ Re-check stem-count estimates against the actual plant numbers after the planter plan is final.
☑ Check dahlia, ranunculus and tulip planting depth in planters against the actual planter depth. Planter depth is 25cm.
☑ (merged into Part 8, approved 30 Oct) List the shopping list (planters, mesh, fleece, insect mesh, hoops, traps, pegs, nematodes, compost, grit, canes); be specific on fleece thickness and insect mesh type and size; mark what is optional.
☑ (merged into Part 8, approved 30 Oct) Add a “week one” page: only what must happen between 29 Oct and 15 Nov.

Tooling

☑ Viewer: full-text search and revision-status banner on chapter 10 added (`viewer/serve.py`).
☑ One navigable PDF (cover, linked contents with page numbers, bookmarks, Parts 1 to 9, appendices for change log, open items and how the project works) is built from the markdown: `python3 tools/build_pdf.py` writes `exports/allotment-bible.pdf`. `source/revised-plan-2026-10-29.html` and `tools/export_pdf.py` are kept only to regenerate `media/gantt-revised.png` and `media/plot-layout.*`.

Found during the merge

☑ Gate (none; south end treated as entrance), tray size and Spring Sunshine as seed confirmed by owner.
☑ Allium variety ignored (owner's instruction). 10 bulbs, all in planter T.
☐ Verify the bed dimensions and perimeters on the ground. They come from the drawing, not a survey.
☑ Shopping list and week-one page merged into Part 8; draft file retired.
☑ The HTML draft is archived in `source/archive/` (README explains it is superseded and only feeds the drawings).
☑ Stem forecast (chart, table, sense check) and countdown built in Part 3 from the plant cards.
☐ Owner to give the list of stems the wedding needs (bouquets, buttonholes, tables) to compare with the forecast.

Appendix C. How this project works (GOALS)

Read this file at the start of every session. It is the only file you must read. Read `TODO.md` only if asked to continue the build-out. Read other files only when your task needs them.

What this project is

A working manual for one person running a brand-new 125 m2 allotment plot (8 m x 15.6 m, top 8 m edge is north) in mild coastal southern England, for the year Oct 2026 to Oct 2027. It is written in plain, practical British English for a beginner.

Intentions, in priority order

Wedding flowers. The owner's wedding is Tuesday 1 June 2027. Flowers are cut on Sunday 30 May 2027. Every decision is judged first by whether it protects or improves that harvest.
Pest and vermin control by design. Mice, voles, squirrels, pigeons, slugs and brassica pests are the main threats. Defence is built into the layout, using mesh, netting and fleece first, and companion planting (chives, marigold, herbs, daffodils, alliums) second and honestly rated as modest.
A full year of veg, herbs and fruit that fits around the wedding crop and rotates sensibly by plant family.
Usable on the plot. Someone standing in the cold with wet hands should find the next job fast: plant cards, month checklists, one operation per bar (sow, pot up, harden off, plant out, harvest).

Standing facts (change only when the owner says so)

Budget is tight. Prefer cheap, free or reusable solutions and say what is optional.
Cold frame: unheated, about 18 standard trays (owner's estimate). Tomatoes, peppers, onions, basil, Didiscus and similar need a warm windowsill, not the frame.
Sweet peas: 40 (Muse, Fire & Ice, High Scent) plus 34 Spring Sunshine, all sown. 48 go on the plot (24 Spring Sunshine in planter S1, 24 of the others in S2, one plant per cane); the other 26 (10 Spring Sunshine, 16 others) go in the owner's home garden.
Raised planters under consideration: 180 × 90 cm, 25 cm deep (owner stated), wire mesh underneath, no base. Current plan is 4 (2 minimum), with 1 needed now and no extenders.
There is no gate and no physical boundary (owner confirmed). The south end, where the main path starts, is treated as the entrance. Tray size 38 × 24 cm and 'Spring Sunshine' as seed are confirmed.
Owner has only 10 alliums (variety unknown).
Dates assume mild southern England; treat as plus or minus 1 to 2 weeks.

How to work on this project

The markdown in `content/` is the source of truth. Chapters are numbered files. Media (images, SVGs) live in `media/` and are linked by relative path (`../media/name.png`). Never embed binary or base64 in markdown.
Iterate; do not rewrite. Make small, targeted edits to the relevant chapter. Keep a chapter's structure and headings stable so diffs stay readable. Do not regenerate chapters from the PDF (`tools/pdf_to_md.py` was a one-off and would erase edits).
Revisions are proposals first. New material goes in `content/10-revisions-*.md` (or a new dated revisions file), marked as draft. When the owner approves, merge it into the right Part and delete or

shorten the revision entry. Record what is pending in `TODO.md`.
Owner proposals arrive in `proposals/inbox.md` (written from the viewer). Triage them into `TODO.md` or act on them, then mark them done there. Do not delete them.
Build out the corpus in markdown. When adding anything (new plants, beds, plans, charts), add or extend markdown first. Charts and drawings are generated from or described alongside markdown, saved to `media/`, and may be regenerated; the markdown holds the facts.
Be honest about uncertainty. Mark assumptions, unverified facts and guesses. Cite sources as links. Say when companion planting has weak evidence. Do not invent variety details; ask or flag.
Keep each chapter self-contained enough to be read alone, and keep the plant cards in the fixed row order (At a glance, Sow / plant, Pinch out, Plant out / space, Support, Protect, Pair with, Keep away from, Back-up plan, Harvest: when, Harvest: how, Stems on 30 May or Yield).
Consistency checks before finishing: plant counts match across chapters; dates agree between the plant card, the month checklist and the calendar; the cold frame never exceeds its tray capacity; sweet peas keep away from onions and chives.

Map

`content/00` to `09`: the original Bible (27 Oct 2026), converted to markdown. `10-...`: revisions of 29 Oct 2026 (drafts).
`media/`: images and SVGs. `source/`: the original PDF and the HTML draft of the revised plan.
`exports/`: generated PDFs.
`viewer/serve.py`: local reader (`python3 viewer/serve.py`). `tools/`: one-off and export scripts.
`TODO.md`: remaining work. `AGENT_PROMPT.md`: prompt for starting a follow-up session.
`proposals/inbox.md`: owner's notes.